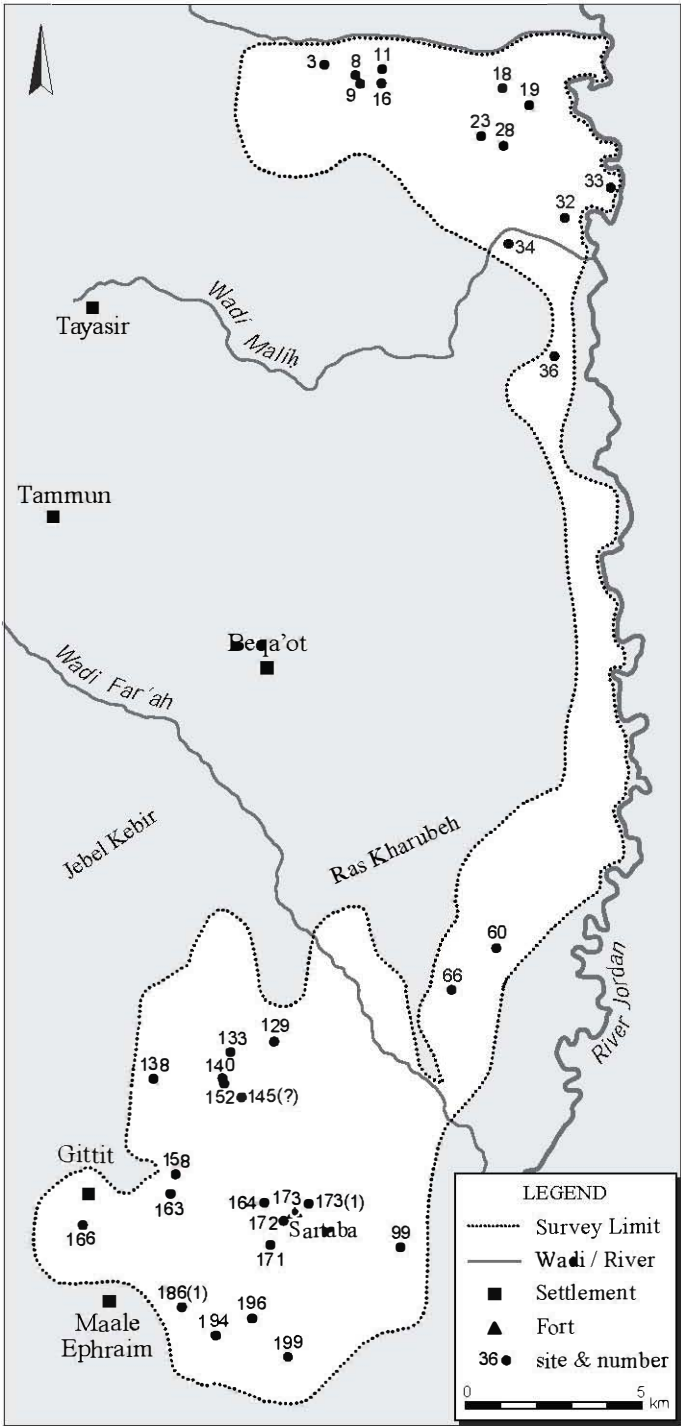
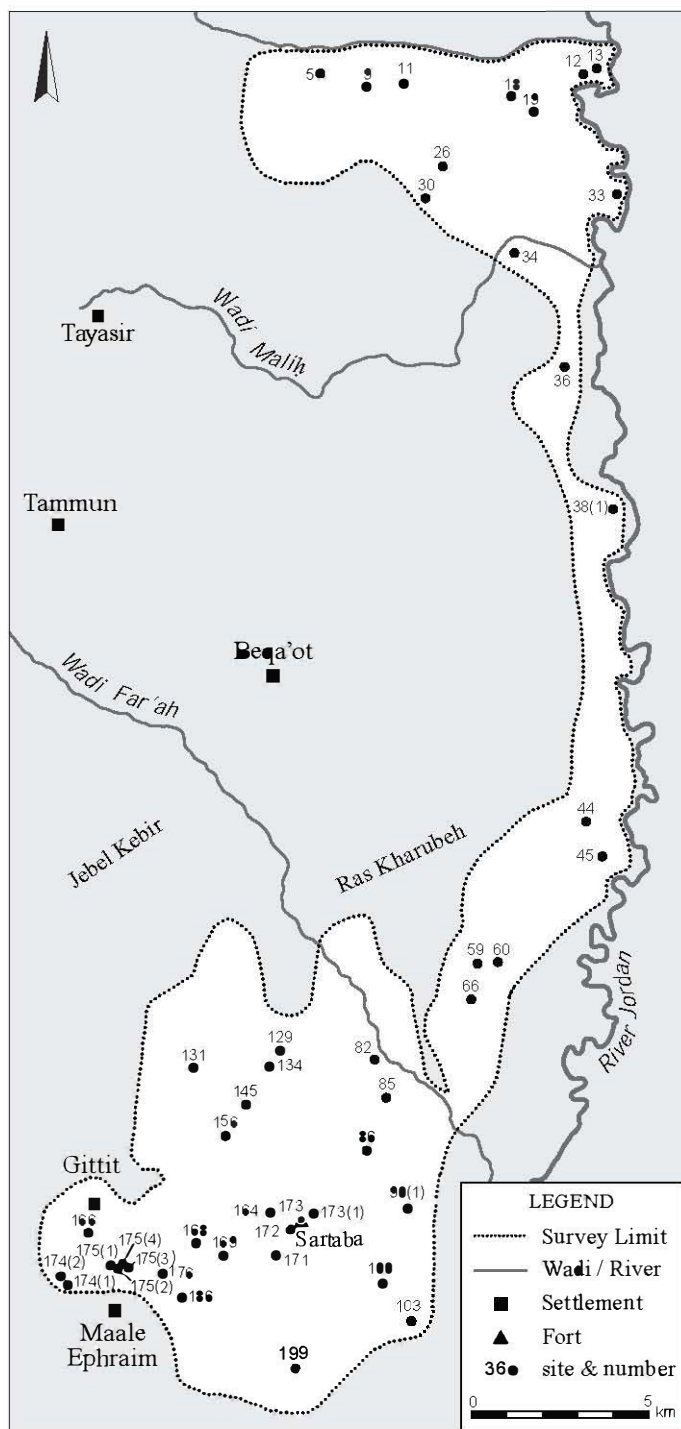
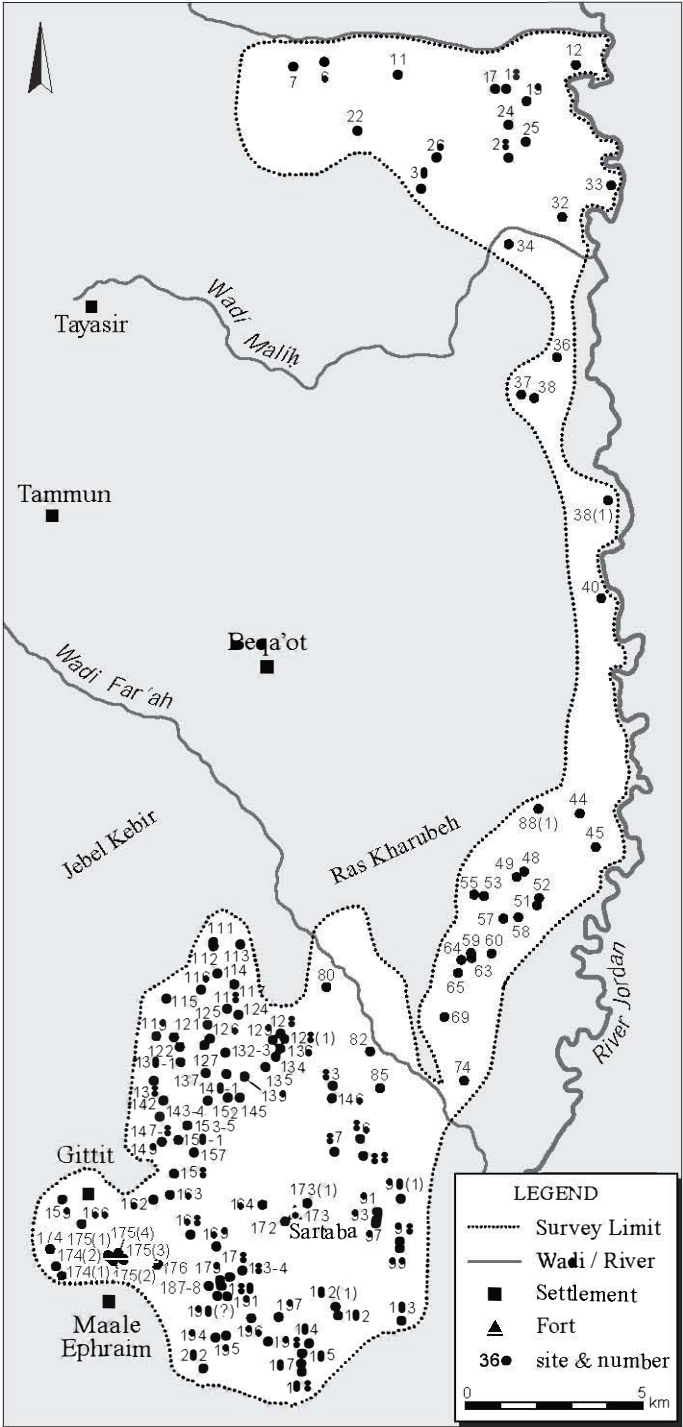




25. Map of the Hellenistic Period sites.



26. Map of the Early Roman Period sites.



27. Map of the Late Roman Period sites.

Landscape Unit	Early Roman	Late Roman
Beit She'an Valley	11	16
Jordan Valley	7	22
Nahal Tirzah	6	21
Sartaba Range	22	81
Total	46	140

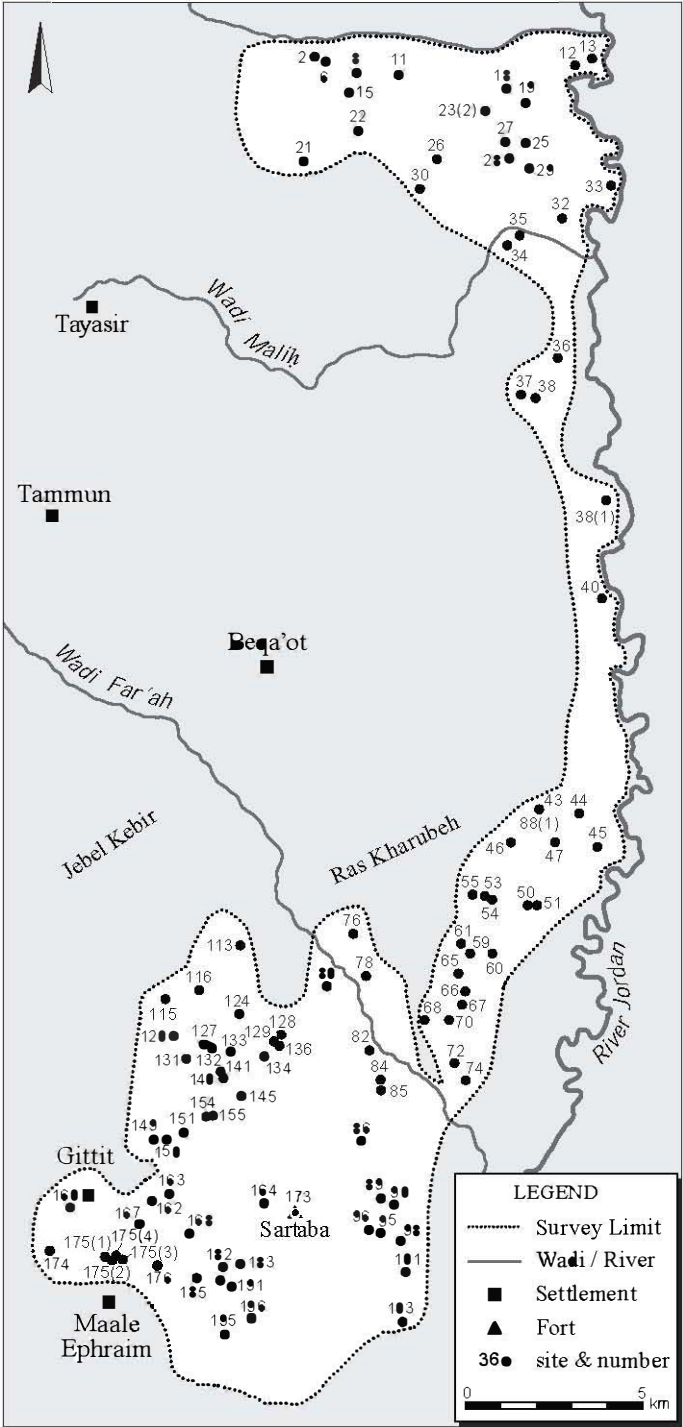
Table 4: Number of sites in the Roman Period – distribution according to landscape units.

In the LR period following the ER, settlement increased three-fold (140 sites): this was the peak of settlement in the region. The increase occurred in all districts, but especially so in the area north-west of the Sartaba. The density here is 1.0 site per sq. km on the average, usually a small farm or enclosure. Agriculture and land utilization reached their maximum in this period. Such a process generally originated from population explosion in the Mediterranean region, or politically-orientated settlement ventures. As to the LR period, we are inclined to link the process to the importance with which the Trajan-Herodian rulers regarded the Jordan Valley. Evidence of this is shown in the well-developed military infrastructure we discovered along the valley, the focus of which is the camp at Kh. es-Suweideh (Hashman 1996; Zertal 2008: site 239). The historical background to this setup is as yet unclear; possibly it was linked to the military actions during the Bar-Kochba uprising in 132-135 CE, or perhaps it represents the strengthening of the *limes* system along the borders of the province.

The fortress of Alexandrion was in a parlous state, or ceased to function altogether, in this period. Some support of the political interpretation of the population influxes in the Jordan Valley (an effort by the authorities to settle the valley and its surroundings) can be made by comparing the IA II and LR periods. It has already been suggested above, that the population influx into the borderland in the IA was based on a project by the northern Kingdom of Israel, and especially by Ahab and his successors. This assumption is based on the rapidity with which the population influx occurred in the borderland of Samaria, and in historical references (Zertal 2001). It is possible that similar action in the LR period resulted in a very similar settlement model in the region.

11. The Byzantine Period (313-632 CE)

Unlike the rest of the country, there was a gradual decline in population in the region during the transition from the LR to the Byzantine period, from 140 sites to 104. The locations of the settlements are identical to those of the preceding period, and the decline is noticeable mainly in the Sartaba region (from



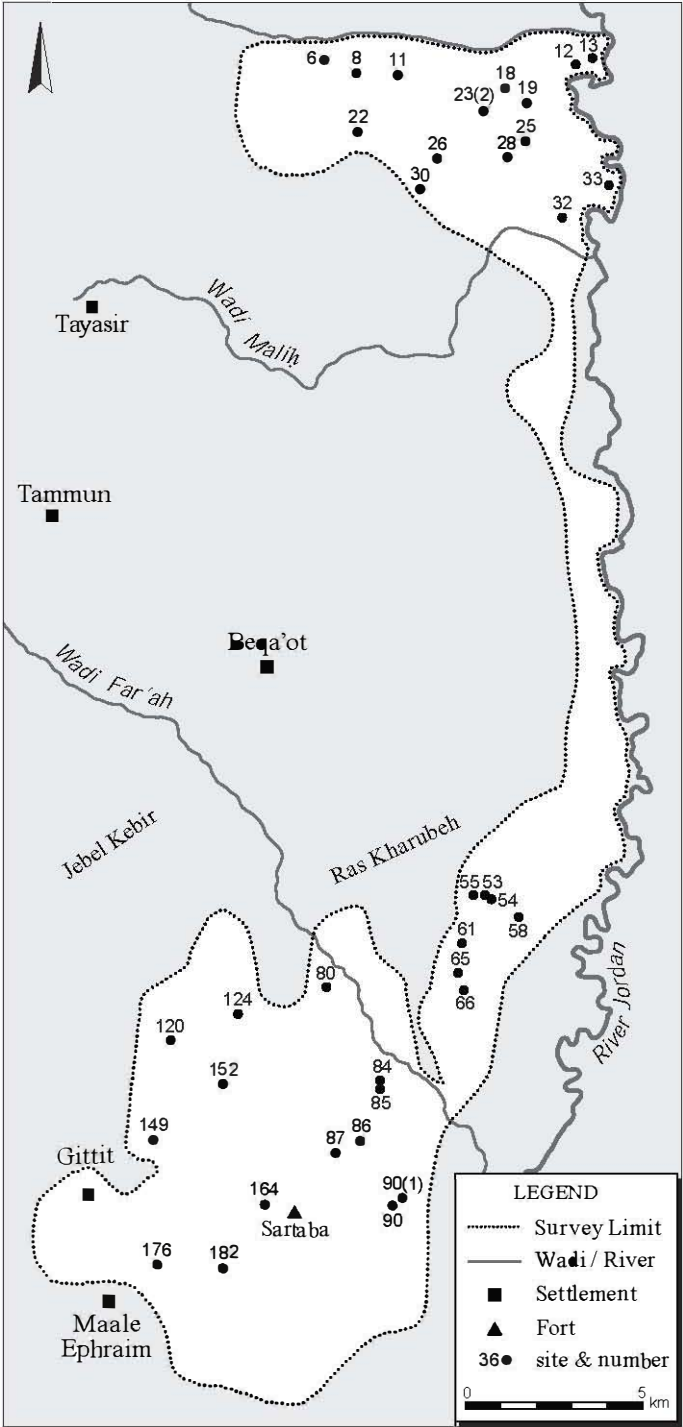
28. Map of the Byzantine Period sites.

81 LR sites to 42 Byzantine). The other regions suffered less from this settlement change, and the units of Beit She'an and the narrow Jordan Valley even witnessed a small increase in the number of sites. In almost all the places in which the Byzantine habitation continued that of the LR period, we witnessed some degree of shrinkage. There were no developed townships typical of the desert fringes during the Byzantine period, common in other districts; for example, Kh. Umm el-'Uqbeh (A) (Zertal 2008: site 114), Kh. Yarzah (B) (Zertal 2008: site 104) and Kh. Jabaris (Zertal 2008: site 69). These townships with public centres and churches were the settlement nuclei of the period. In the region this model was prominent in the Wadi Maliḥ and Ras Jadir areas (Zertal 2008), and in the west, primarily the township of Khirbet Ṭana et-Tahta (Bar and Zertal 2016: site 47). The only example of a township in the region is Kh. es-Sakut (Site 32). It may be that the large Byzantine city of Scythopolis attracted an urban population, leaving a relative settlement vacuum around it, and only a few townships or large settlements were recorded. In the territory south of that described in this volume; that is, in the Jordan Valley south of the Sartaba, we found two such townships: Kh. Fusail (Fasaelis [Zertal 2012a: site 34]) and Kh. Beiyudhat (Archelais [Zertal 2012a: site 111]).

12. The Early Moslem Period (632-1099 CE)

The 36 EM sites represent a population decline common to the entire land. However, the severity of the decline in this region is surprising, because of the considerable development in Jericho and its vicinity. During the Umayyad and Abbasid dynasties there was a momentum in the Jordan Valley, expressed by the erection of the Hisham's Palace north of Jericho, various irrigation projects and sugar cane cultivation. All this activity was perhaps connected to the desert concept of the Umayyad and Abbasid rulers (for example, their desert palaces east of Amman; Porath 1985: 163, 172-173). The agricultural activities, such as the site at the outlet of Wadi Rashash (Nahal Fasael) into the Jordan Valley (el-Hisha – Zertal 2012a: site 26) – according to the pottery this was a sugar refining installation – and the palace building, were based upon royal projects.

In many other places in which the EM sites carried on from the earlier Byzantine ones the population shrank, and a web of small settlements remained – villages, farms and enclosures. This is evidence of a population of poor villagers and shepherds, while the main state and sugar growing activity occurred in the Beit She'an district and south of the Sartaba in the areas next to the River Jordan. The principal settlements the region were Tell el-Ridhghah (Site 18), Tell ed-Deir (Site 28), Kh. es-Sakut (Site 32) and Tell eṣ-Ṣimadi (Site 84). The coarse pottery of the sugar cane production vessels



29. Map of the Early Moslem Period sites.

has been found in all of them, and it seems that the inhabitants engaged in this occupation.

13. The Middle Ages (1099-1534 CE)

This long period, more than 400 years, includes Crusader and Mamluk rule. The 84 sites with MA sherds represent a significant increase in the number of settlements and population. The number of settlements increased mainly in the narrow Jordan Valley and in the Sartaba range. In the Beit She'an Valley and Nahal Tirzah the number of settlements was about the same as in the EM period.

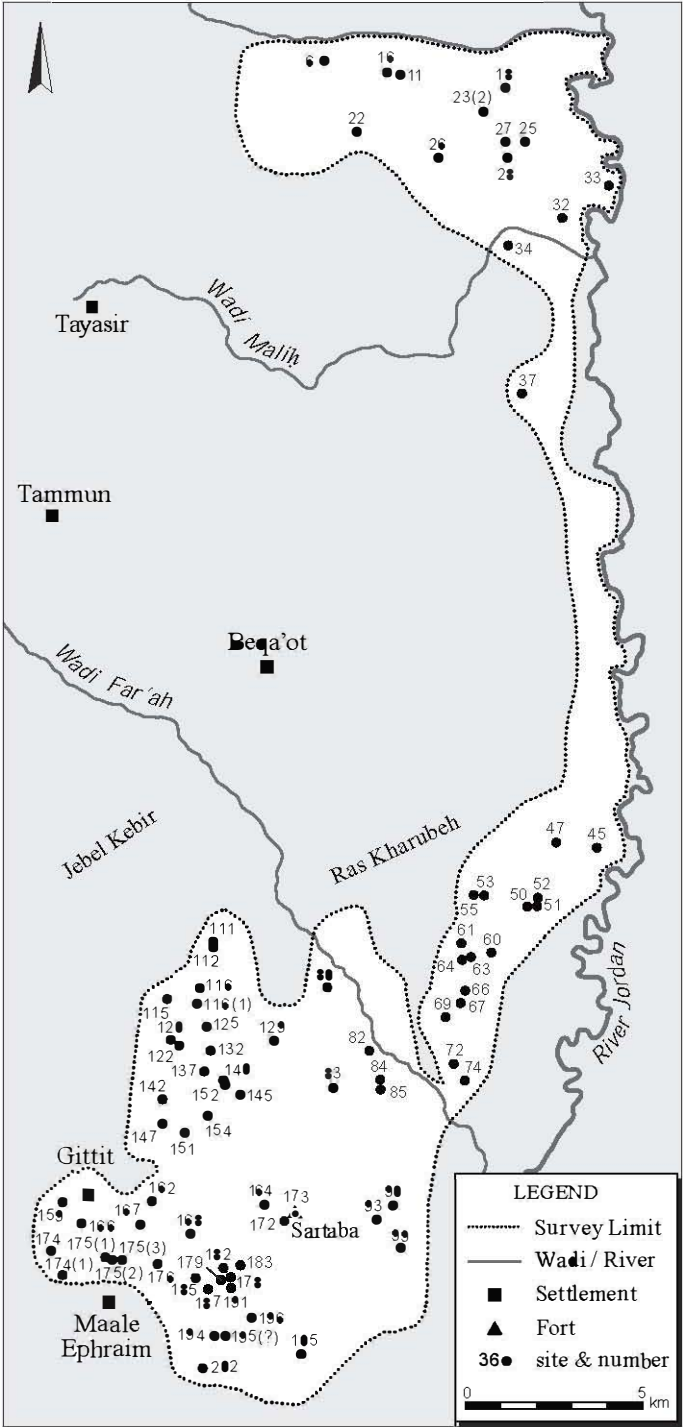
Most of the sites in the Beit She'an area are tells, and in our opinion, the mostly urban population concentrated on sugar production. As in the earlier periods, sugar production vessels were found in Tell el-Ridhghah (Site 18), Tell ed-Deir (Site 28), Kh. es-Sakut (Site 32) and other sites. Along the Beit She'an-Jericho road in the narrow Jordan Valley there were mainly small sites, especially cave and courtyard/enclosure sites.

Much sugar production pottery was found in Nahal Tirzah in Tell eš-Šimadi and its lower city – Korai (Karaweh in the Moslem sources) (Sites 84-85). MA sherds, mainly from the Mamluk period, were found in sites around the Sartaba. Here 45 settlements were found, more than half of the total in this period. MA pottery was found in many places founded in the Roman-Byzantine periods. It is difficult to know if this was a return to the settlements due to the economic prosperity of the Jordan Valley, or a state project aimed at strengthening the population.

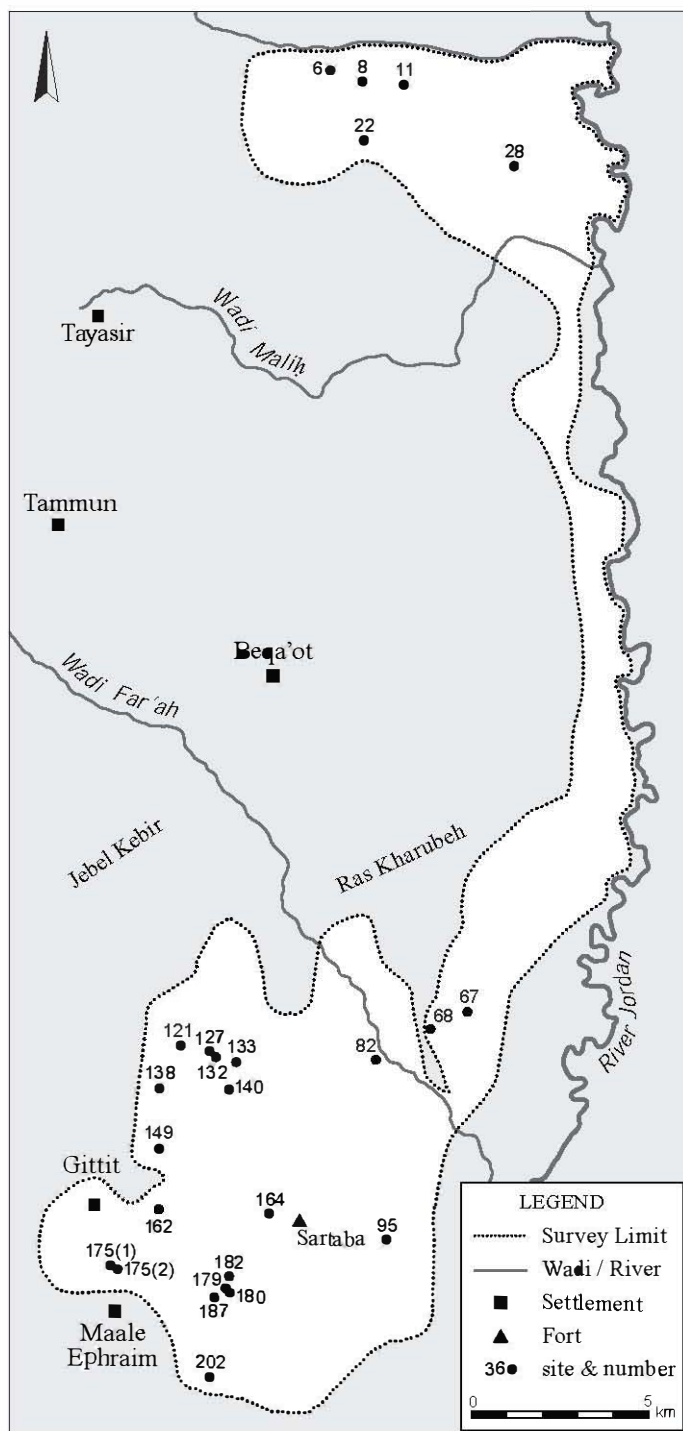
The historical sources note a great interest in the region at the beginning of Moslem rule – from the Umayyad Caliphate to the beginning of the Mamluk reign (Gil 1981: 58, 152; Porath 1985: 163, 172-173). This interest was expressed by the funds given to these districts and agricultural and industrial development.

14. The Ottoman Period (1534-1917 CE)

The 25 Ottoman period sites, represent another dramatic decline in population. This is typical of all parts of Israel and Syria, but is particularly apparent in the fringe districts (Cohen 1998: 150), such as eastern Samaria and the Jordan Valley. Only a quarter of the earlier settlements survived, and most of the preceding period's settlements were abandoned. The area was overrun by Bedouin tribes, and evidence of this can already be found in the Ottoman 1596 CE census (Hütteroth and Abdulfattah 1977). At that time the district was called Gawr (*Ghor*) and was solely inhabited by Bedouin tribes.



30. Map of the Middle Ages Period sites.



31. Map of the Ottoman Period sites.

E. OUTLINE OF THE HISTORY OF THE REGION

This volume is a partial review: represented in it are sections of the Beit She'an Valley, the narrow Jordan Valley, the Nahal Tirzah floodplain and the Sartaba range. Hence, the reviewed historical chapters do not stand by themselves because history cannot be judged from small and isolated districts. Landscape Unit 27 is the connection between the city of Beit She'an and the narrow Jordan Valley (Landscape Unit 28). Landscape Unit 29 (the Nahal Tirzah floodplain) is the connection between the Central Hill Country and the Jordan Valley and Jordan. The Sartaba range (Landscape Unit 30) enjoys a special history, linked to the Jordan Valley, the Samaria fringes and the Jericho district. In these deliberations we try to link these units to the general history of the region.

1. The ancient periods (Early and Middle Bronze Age – the 3rd millennium and the first half of the 2nd millennium BCE)

In the EBA, extremely well represented in the Beit She'an Valley and in Nahal Tirzah (but not in the narrow Jordan Valley), there are very few historical sources. From the first half of the 2nd millennium – the MBA II period, there are several sources. The first one is the Execration Texts (Sethe 1926; Posener 1940; ANET: 328-329; Mazar 1980b). In these texts, from the first quarter of the 2nd millennium BCE, are magical execrations against potential rebels against Egypt. They contain lists of rulers and cities in Canaan. The question is if and to what extent the Jordan Valley and the desert fringes are represented in this list. In our opinion, it is feasible that the border districts of the western land of Israel and Jordan are mentioned in the Execration Texts. Mazar (1980b: 14-15) connects the settlement expansion of the MBA II (expressed in the Execration Texts) with the development of trade routes. Another possible factor is the considerable settlement of IBA populace in the desert fringes, parts of which are included in this volume. Their groups of settlements were found in the south of the Beit She'an Valley (Sites 1-7), in the northern Buqe'ah (Zertal 2008: sites 119-120, 123-125 and others), the narrow Jordan Valley (Site 41), and Nahal Tirzah (the large site in Wadi Zeith and Khallet el-Fuleh – Site 81)(review in Bar 2015b). It seems that at the beginning of MBA II, these settlements were known and recorded in the Execration Texts. Perhaps there was some degree of contact between the inhabitants in both periods.

From the places in Posener's list of the Execration Texts it is perhaps possible to connect to our district E3 (Ashanu-Beit She'an) and E4 (hmw). The latter was identified by Posener and Mazar with Beth-Haram (Tell Iktanu in Moab [?]), east of the Survey area, but the identification is doubtful. The next site is E7 (kn), identified by Mazar (1980b: 25) with Qinna or Ginna, which is

Jenin; but its placing in the list next to Shechem (E6) and Pehel or Pihlum (E8) suggests a new identification in the Qa'un area. Indeed, the Qa'un area was a settlement centre during both the IBA and MBA II periods. If E14 (hbwm) is the city of Rehov in the Beit She'an Valley, then here is an additional reference to the region.

Apart from the city lists, the groups of tribes are also worth mentioning: these are E50-51 (Kwsu) and E52-53 (Swtu), which are probably connected to the mentions of Cush or Kush and Seth in the Bible. Albright (1941: 34, note 8; 1944: 220) was the first to suggest identifying Kwsu with Biblical Cushan, "I saw the tents of Cushan in affliction; the curtains of the land of Midian did tremble" (Habakkuk 3:7). The regions in which the tribes of Cushan wandered remain an open question; Mazar (1980b: 17) defined them as follows: "These areas most probably lay in the south-eastern borderland of the land and in the nearby deserts, from Moab to the border of Egypt".

Cush of Numb 12: 1 and II Chron 14: 8 is not identical to the Cushim, mentioned as a people in Nubia, south of Egypt (Liver 1970: 65-68; Redford 1992). The Cush in question reside "in the land of the Negev or south-eastern borderland of the Land of Israel" (Liver 1970: 69). Others (Hutton 1992) place Cushu and Shutu east of the Jordan, and there is no reason not to expand the boundaries of their wanderings into the fringes of the Samaria desert.

Another source is the Story of Sinuhe, part of the memoirs of an Egyptian priest who wandered in Canaan, Syria and Jordan during the days of Amenhat I of the 12th Dynasty (ANET: 18-22). After he left Gebi (Byblos), Sinuhe arrived in the Land of Kedem in which he spent many years. This land is defined as "Highland country, probably including northern Palestine, southern and central Syria" (ANET: 19, n. 12). The characteristics of the Land of Kedem (also named the Land of Yaa) are connected to Mediterranean agriculture: there are figs and grapes, "more wine than water... honey and olives, barley and millet and also....no limit to any (kind of) cattle". In Sinuhe's menu appear bread and wine, cooked meat and fowl, and also beasts of the desert, hunted and served to him. It is clear from the text that the Land of Yaa is located in a Mediterranean region not far from the desert. Does this description fit the MBA II sites that have been discovered in eastern Samaria? (There are not many in Volume 4, and they are mainly located west of the Jordan Valley in territory appearing in Volumes 2, 5 and 6).

2. The Late Bronze Age Period (the Egyptian Empire, ElAmarna and the Egyptian military conquest)

This period is relatively rich in historical sources and poor in archaeological finds, as is seen in the preceding volumes. Most of the settlements are tells in

the south of the Beit She'an Valley (Landscape Unit 27), with Tell el-Ḥammeh (Site 30) at their centre. Beit She'an is mentioned in Thutmose III's list from his first expedition (No. 110, ANET: 242). Rehov, which is south of Beit She'an, is also mentioned in Ta'anach Letter No. 2 (in the form of Rahabu – Albright 1944: 12ff). Ahi-ma, Rehov's master, also appears. Pehel, which is next to Tell el-Ḥammeh east of the River Jordan, is also mentioned in numerous sources.

This territory is also mentioned in the two Beit She'an Egyptian stele, unearthed in the University of Pennsylvania excavations and published by Rowe (1930: 24ff; and see also Gradseloff 1949). Both are from the time of Seti I (1291-1279 BCE according to the low chronology). In the first, interpreted also by Wilson (ANET: 253-254), the issue is an enemy gathering at Ḥammeht and a conspiracy with the King of Pehel to capture Beit She'an. Egyptian army units were sent to Pehel, Yenoam and Ḥammeht, and in the ensuing battle defeated the rebels. This hints to the importance of the city-state of Ḥammeht, identified by most scholars with Tell el-Ḥammeh. The stela presents the following course of events:

On this day (year I, 3rd month of the third season, day 10) one came to speak to his majesty, as follows: "The wretched foe who is in the town of Hamath is gathering to himself many people, while he is seizing the town of Beth-Shan. Then there will be an alliance with them of Pehel. He does not permit the Prince of Rehob to go outside." Thereupon his majesty sent the first army of Amon, (named) "Mighty of Bows," to the town of Hamath, the first army of Re, (named) "Plentiful of Valor," to the town of Beth-Shan, and the first army of Seth, (named) "Strong of Bows," to the town of Yanoam. When the space of a day had passed, they were overthrown to the glory of his majesty, the King of Upper and Lower Egypt: Men-maat-Re; the Son of Re: Seti Mer-ne-Ptah, given life (ANET: 253-254).

Confirming Seti's Beit She'an victory stele are the topographical lists from Karnak in Egypt. In this source, the Seti reliefs on the northern wall of Karnak temple, appear the names Pehel – [p3-h]y-[r3] – No. 49, Ḥammeht – h3-m[y]-t – No. 50, Beit She'an – b3-t s[3]-r[3] – No. 51 and Yenoam – y-[nw-c3-mw] – No. 52 (Ahituv 1979: 66, in which there is a reference to Noth's analysis).

Ḥammeht from the Seti I lists was first identified by Albright (1924-1925; 1925a) as Tell el-Ḥammeh (Site 30). The identification fits the location (south of Beit She'an and Rehov), the finds (LBA) and the preservation of the name. However, at the beginning of the translation of the Egyptian text in ANET (253, note 5), Wilson remarks that the name does not necessarily refer to that city: if the inhabitants of the city were the issue the text would have been written

as "the miserable enemy from the city of IḤammeht" and not "in the city of Ḥammeht": hence, in his opinion, it may refer to another city in the north, because Seti sent his army northward to Yenoam.

The results of the excavations in the tell, which did not reach the layers from Seti's period, do not solve the problem of identification. Some difficulties remain: for example, the area of the top of the tell is very limited. According to the Emergency Survey it is 5000 sq. m, while Tzori makes it 1 ha. The area stated in this volume (3 ha) includes the tell and its slopes, and also the eastern part on the shoulder, on which possibly lay a lower city. On the very summit there is room for a structure or two, and the comparison of the areas of the cities in the Amarna letters to that of Tell el-IḤammeh raises doubts as to the suitability of the location as a city-state. Tell Abu Sus (Site 33), where LBA pottery was found in abundance, could equally well be the site.

The second stele from Beit She'an, published by Gradseloff (1949) and discussed by Albright (1952), deals with the "Apiru of Mount Yarmutu". They were allied with a group called Tayaru, both attacking another group named Ruhma. The text deals with a local dispute between nomads, resolved by the Egyptians: but the important thing is the very mention of the 'Apiru. Indeed, the geographical linkage is not clear, and it is difficult to tell if the 'Apiru lived in any specific area, and where that was. Mazar (1962: 16) identified it with the Issachar plateau north of Beit She'an. However, this notion, based on its resemblance of the Jarmuth of the Levites in Issachar (Josh 21: 29) to Belvoir, is problematic. Gal (1980: 84), who surveyed the Issachar plateau, also doubts Mazar's idea. Gal's argument is based upon the small population of the Issachar plateau at the end of the LBA and the beginning of the IA I. From that viewpoint, it is possible, as already suggested with reservations by Zertal (2008: 57), to assume that the 'Apiru area was south of the Beit She'an Valley in the desert fringes of Manasseh and the Jordan Valley. There is some support for this in the 13th century BCE settlements in the eastern valleys, and also in the many mentions of the 'Apiru in the Amarna letters in connection with Labayu and the hill country of Shechem.

From all the above it seems that the southern Beit She'an Valley was an arena for local rebellions at the beginning of the 13th century BCE, a borderland territory over which the Egyptians did not enjoy full control.

3. *Iron Age I (the Israelite settlement)*

During this period the historical text is enriched with new material – the Biblical descriptions of the Israelite settlement. These stimulated and still stimulate contentious debate regarding their date and credibility. It has been suggested (Zertal 2000: 245-246) that a thorough archaeological survey is one of the most efficient methods of examining the Biblical source. In such an exercise the single site, its location and environment are examined first: only then comes the comparison with the text.

The Jordan Valley, and especially the area between the Damia Bridge and Jericho, is one of the most important links between the eastern side of the Jordan and the Central Hill Country. This region is related to several Biblical traditions, reviewed briefly below:

1. The passage through the Jordan Valley: the Deuteronomistic traditions in Deut 11: 29-30; 27: 1-11 imply that the Israelite tribes crossed the Jordan to the ceremonies at Mt Ebal and Gerizim via Nahal Tirzah. This is the plausible interpretation of “And when you have crossed over the Jordan, you shall set up...on Mount Ebal, and you shall plaster them with plaster” (Deut 27: 4). “And on the day...” (Deut 27: 2) is interpreted as “travel by the shortest way, the first thing you will do” (Zertal 2000: 298). Sellin (1917) first suggested that what is implied here is an independent tradition and entry route avoiding Jericho. This idea evolved during his excavations in Jericho and Shechem. As a result of the French digs at Tell el-Far’ah (Tirzah), de Vaux, and after him de Pury (1969) and Lemaire (1978; 1982; 1984), suggested Nahal Tirzah as the principal route of the Israelites. This proposition, which was based solely upon literary analysis, has a certain resemblance to the picture we suggest (Zertal 2000: 240-259). According to our survey, Nahal Tirzah served as the natural route through which elements of the Israelite tribes passed westward from the Jordan Valley, and with archaeological testimony to the ‘northern tradition’ in Deuteronomy. This testimony includes the Survey finds (the sites in Nahal Tirzah and its vicinity), the excavations at Mount Ebal, the site of el-’Unuq (Zertal 2008: site 160), hypothetically identified with the *Gilgal* of Deut 11: 30, and the other *Gilgal* sites presented in this volume (Appendices B and C).

2. The ‘altar of imposing size’ described in Joshua 22. There is a tradition about the conflict between the tribes assembled in Shiloh and the tribes from across the Jordan. According to the story, the latter assisted in the conquest of the land, and after their return across the Jordan built an ‘imposing altar’ “...at the frontier of the land of Canaan, in the region about the Jordan” (Josh 22:11). The construction of the altar caused a rift between the two groups of tribes, and those at Shiloh decided to launch a war against Gad, Reuben and the half-tribe of Manasseh. Only thanks to a goodwill delegation, headed by Phineas,

son of Eleazar the priest, was war prevented. The compromise was reached by the promise of the tribes from across the Jordan to transform the imposing altar into a 'witness' (monument) altar, and to refrain from using it for offerings or sacrifices.

We suggest that this is a historical kernel, the focus of which is a struggle between the central site of worship at Shiloh and the other cultic site established in the vicinity of the Adam (Damia) bridge, east or west of the River Jordan. And indeed, other traditions in Hosea (6: 7-9) and Psalms (78: 59-60), apparently deal with the founding of a centre competing with Shiloh. The segment from Psalms 78 is a sort of abstract of the ancient chronicles of the people of Israel. After discussing the entry into the Land of Canaan (Psalms 78: 52-57), the chapter deals with the abandonment (punishment) of Shiloh (Psalms 78: 59-60) and the possible shifting of the cultic centre from Shiloh to the area of the city of Adam in the Jordan Valley.

Hosea's prophecy also deals with this subject. After the prophet talks about Ephraim and Israel (chapter 6) he deals with the crime at Adam: "But like Adam they transgressed the covenant; there they dealt faithlessly with me. Gilead is a city of them that work iniquity, and is polluted with blood. As robbers lie in wait for a man ["adam", A.Z.], so the priests band together; they murder on the way to Shechem; they commit villainy" (Hosea 6: 7-9). The great majority of commentators (Beeby 1989: 77-79; Hubbard 1989: 128-130; Garrett 1998: 162-165; Landy 2011: 92-96) presume that the reference here is to the geographical name of the city of Adam (in contrast to other opinions and the usual translation of the text into English, after the name of Adam the first man). Support of this is the term 'there' and the geographical sequence Gilead-Adam-Shechem, according to which the transgression of the covenant happened between Gilead and Shechem. The nature of the event is unclear, although only a few dispute its actual occurrence. Some assume that the issue was a political or religious event in the 8th century BCE (Beeby 1989: 77-79; Hubbard 1989: 128-130); but it seems that it was already a remote event in Hosea's time. A faint echo of the affair is also possibly present in Psalm 68: 19.

Goitein (1947), and Mazar after him (1986: 169-171), suggested that the issue is an authentic tradition, the hub of which is a cultic centre in the Jordan Valley. Mazar suggested that the 'imposing altar' was next to the river itself; but scholars differ as to its location.

The discoveries around the Sartaba, mainly the clusters of IA I settlements, focus the attention on that area. Especially interesting are the three 'foot-shaped enclosures', the largest of which is Bedhat esh-Sha'ab next to Argaman (Site 65). The results of the excavations at the site (Appendix B) suggest that it was a place of assembly and/or cult. The enclosure was not used as an animal pen or dwelling place, and was not fortified. No houses were found, and its

location at the foot of a rocky slope supports its interpretation as a place of assembly. A large courtyard, a circular stone structure/*bama*, and a processional way round part of the site's perimeter were also exposed. No parallels to these enclosures and the sites surrounding them have been found in the country or in Jordan. Hosea's prophecy, together with the verses from Psalms and Josh 22, introduce new possibilities. Perhaps it is possible to link the sites around the Sartaba to a cult near the town of Adam, competing with Shiloh.

3. Gideon and the pursuit of the Midianites. The invasion of the Jezreel Valley by the Midianites, and their defeat and flight (Judg 6: 7-8, 33-40) occurred in the north of our search area. The flight of the Midianites from west to east and the capture of the Jordan crossings by Ephraim under Gideon's command is described as: "And the army fled as far as Beth-shittah toward Zererah, as far as the border of Abel-Meholah, by Tabbath" (Judg 7: 22).

The general area in which this took place is agreed by all, but the geographical details are not obvious, and none of the sites along the escape route of the invaders has been identified. Various scholars (Avi-Yonah and Yeivin 1973; Thompson 1992) linked Beit-Shittah to Arab Shatah in the Beit She'an Valley, and Oded (1971) linked Zererah to Zeredah and Zarethan. However, these locations could not be linked to our research in the field, and of them only Abel-Meholah has been identified with any certain degree of certainty. If the crossing of the Jordan took place south of Beit She'an, then its location is in the Tell Abu Sus area, or one of the tells in its vicinity. By repeating Mittmann and Zobel's suggestion of identifying the site as Tell Abu Sus (Site 33), Tzori relied upon the crossings next to it. Glueck (1943: 12) based the location on the 'edge' in Deut 2: 36, and suggested that Abel Meholah's 'edge' is the plateau overlooking the Valley of Tabbath; while Loewenstamm (1972: 38) presumed that the meaning is the 'riverbank'. The place reappears in King Solomon's Fifth Administrative District: "... Ta'anach, Megiddo, and all Beit She'an that is beside Zarethan below Jezreel, and from Beit Shean to Abel-Meholah, as far as the other side of Jokmeam" (I Kgs 4: 12). Albright (1925b: 32ff.) suggested emending the text to read: "Taanach and Megiddo as far as the other side of Jokmeam and all Beit Shean below Jezreel from Beit Shean to Abel-Meholah that is beside Zarethan". This emendation improves the route of the administrative district boundary. An additional mention occurs in the course of the Elijah narratives in I Kgs 19: 16, 19: "And Jehu the son of Nimshi you shall anoint to be king over Israel, and Elisha the son of Shaphat of Abel-Meholah you shall anoint to be prophet in your place" (I Kgs 19: 16). Scholars based the location on this and verse 19, although there is no geographical relation.

Summing up, the many traditions in this period deal with the crossing of the Jordan into Canaan, and the transition from nomadism or semi-nomadism (as appears from the many enclosures) to permanent settlement. Especially

significant here are the entry at the middle of the Jordan valley and the hints of a cultic hub in the vicinity of the Adam Bridge.

4. *Iron Age II (the Israelite Kingdom)*

Two factors were significant in this period: the impetus of settlement, and the contact across the Jordan (for a general review of the latter see Oded 1982).

The first aspect includes the intensive settlement in the Jordan Valley, particularly around the Sartaba. This is one of the peaks of population density here and in eastern Samaria in general, possibly based upon preplanned settlement by the Kingdom of Israel.

The second aspect is the role which the region played in the connection between the eastern and western parts of the Land of Israel. The northern Kingdom of Israel and the stages of its creation were strongly linked to Jordan and the Israelite tribes which settled there. The tribe of Manasseh which settled on both sides of the River Jordan is particularly important in this discussion. Below are summarized some of the issues:

1. The shift of the capital cities of the Kingdom of Israel from west to east, and vice versa, testifies to the balance between the hubs of power in the initial stages of the Kingdom. The capital was moved from Shechem to Penuel across the Jordan (I Kgs 12: 25), and from there to Tirzah (I Kgs 15: 33), and then to Samaria (I Kgs 16: 23-25). The shifting of the capital, typical of many states in the ancient Near East, signifies the shifting of the hubs of political power. The establishment of the capital at Shechem shows its importance as a religious and political centre, preceding, and as important as Jerusalem. The shift to Penuel by Jeroboam necessitated establishing communications, building roads and fording the Jordan. Testimony to this are the three roads ascending westward (Wadi Malih, Nahal Tirzah and the Fasaal-Shechem road), protected by forts. It is reasonable to assume that royal forts protected the main roads, judging by their identical shape – a circular fort of the 'Malfuf' type with a rectangular structure of several rooms next to it. The pair of forts east of the Sartaba with a similar plan controlled the Beit She'an-Jericho road, and perhaps belonged to a system of fortifications of the Kingdom. The Aramaean incursions into Israel and Samaria regularly passed through the area of the Survey, and there is no doubt as to the great importance of the Jordan crossing next to the Adam Bridge. Yadin (1973: 178-179) suggested (rightly in our opinion) that the Succoth Valley, east of the Jiftlik, was the base camp of the Aramaean army for the attack on Samaria, and see below.

2. Solomon's Districts. Solomon's Fifth Administrative District is described thus: "...Ta'anach, Megiddo, and all Beit Shean that is beside Zarethan below Jezreel, and from Beit She'an to Abel-Meholah, as far as the other side of

Jokmeam" (I Kgs 4: 12). The description of the border is from west to east – from Ta'anach and Megiddo to Beit She'an. If Albright's assumption that Zarethanah is wrongly placed (because Zarethan is situated in the mid-Jordan Valley) is correct, then there is logic in the order of the sites: "below Jezreel" might be the areas north of the tell, in the valley; "all Beit She'an" is probably the area belonging to the city-state of Beit She'an (see Zertal 1984: 65-68, which presents the difference between 'the Land of Heffer' – the core area of the city-state – and "All the Land of Heffer" – its extended area). In this case Tell Abu Sus (Site 33; Abel Meholah?) also fits with the eastern boundary of the Fifth District. Jokmeam has not yet been satisfactorily identified. Mazar suggested identifying it as Tell eṣ-Šimadi (Site 84; see the Identifications chapter below), but accepting this creates a long stretch along the Jordan Valley which has no geographical logic. This identification also conflicts with the location of Ataroth on the Manasseh-Ephraim boundary (Josh 16: 6-7). We therefore suggest identifying Jokmeam at Tell Qa'un or Tell Mukehaz (Sites 3, 11) – see Chapter 2.

3. Shoshenq's expedition. On his way from the upper hill country to the Jordan Valley the Egyptian king descended by one of the existing approach roads. According to the list, Migdal (No. 58) was situated between Beth-Horon and Gibeon and Zemaraim, Adamah and Succoth (Mazar 1980c: 237). Aljitiv, following Abel and Noth, suggested identifying Migdal as Majdal Bani-Fadel (Mazar 1980c: note 10A). With the discovery of the circular IA forts located at the heads of the roads ascending westwards and their Migdal-type shapes, we suggest identifying the fort at Rujm Abu-Muḥeir, south of the Sartaba, with Migdal in the Shoshenq list.

4. The siege of Samaria and the wars against Aram. The discovery of the IA II fort system around the town of Samaria (Zertal 1998a) offers additional information about Aram's military expeditions against the Kingdom of Israel. In the second half of the 9th century BCE Ben-Hadad attacked Samaria with a large army (I Kgs 20: 1-21). According to Yadin's interpretation of I Kgs 20: 12, the location of the main camp of the Aramaean army was in the valley of Succoth on the other side of the Jordan, opposite the Jiftlik (Yadin 1973: 178-180). If this interpretation is correct, then it means that Ben-Hadad issued threats against Samaria from the Succoth Valley. After the rejection of Ben-Hadad's terms he ascended via Nahal Tirzah to lay siege to the capital city. It is deduced from I Kgs 20: 12 that Ben-Hadad laid siege to Samaria, and when he retreated the Israelites ambushed and defeated him. Yadin (1973: 179-180) maintained that the battle took place in Nahal Tirzah, while Zertal (1998a: 21) thinks that the ambush was set on one of the narrow roads linking Tirzah (Tell el-Far'ah) with Samaria.

The second expedition to Samaria of Ben Hadad III, son of Hazael (II Kgs 6: 24-33; 7: 1-17) occurred at the end of the 9th century or early in the 8th century BCE. At that stage the city was immediately besieged, and after the failure of the siege the Aramaean army escaped eastwards via Nahal Tirzah. For the Assyrian campaign against Samaria (II Kgs 18: 9), there are no details regarding the approach roads. In all these cases the district served as a logical approach route to the capital, and this view is supported by the forts discovered during the Survey.

5. The Assyrian (Iron Age III) and Persian periods

The Survey shows that the population was sparse during these periods. With the annihilation or decline of the well-developed settlement from the days of the Kingdom of Israel and for reasons already discussed (Zertal 2001), the valley remained a sparsely inhabited border zone. The Assyrian and Persian cultures were economically and ethnically Mediterranean by nature, and scarcely mention the desert and the desert fringes. There is no archaeological verification of Lemaire's view (1994: 46-55) that the kingdoms of Moab and Ammon existed during the Persian period. According to Parker (1997: 235) there are few remains from the Persian period in Jordan. The copper mines were abandoned, and the Persian Empire had little interest in these regions.

Ilan (1973: 83) introduces Avi-Yona's interpretation of some of the geographical data in the Book of Judith from the Persian era; suggesting, for example, the identification of Abelmaim with Abel-Meḥolah. However, there is no archaeological evidence, and the population during the Persian period was too sparse.

6. The Hellenistic period (Ptolemaic and Seleucid rule and the Hasmonean period)

There was new interest in the Jordan Valley in these periods. There was some recovery of population in both the Beit She'an Valley and around the Sartaba. The relevant historical references are related to the military expeditions of the Hellenistic kings and the Hasmonean desert forts, especially around Alexandrion. With the Hellenistic conquest of the country in 332 BCE, Alexander the Great sent emissaries to assess the yields of fragrance of Jericho (Gutmann 1940) in order to collect taxes. Ben Sira 24: 14 (Meeks 1993) notes 'Ein-Gedi as an exemplar for fertility: "I grew tall like a palm tree in En-Gedi, and like rosebushes in Jericho".

The Beit She'an-Jericho road is mentioned before the Battle of Elasa

during the second expedition of the Seleucid warlord Bacchides in 160 BCE (Bar-Kochva 1980: 365-369). In I Macc 9: 2 (Meeks 1993) appears the account: "They went by the road that leads to Gilgal and encamped against Mesaloth in Arbela". Bar-Kochva (1980: 290) maintains that "the road that leads to Gilgal" refers to the Jordan Valley; however, there are other options. The accounts of the campaigns conducted by Bacchides against Yonatan (Jonathan) the Hasmonean and his men (I Macc 9: 43-49), included the crossing of the Jordan by Yonatan, but there is no accurate description of the place. After the battle the Seleucid leader built a fortress in Jericho (I Macc 9: 50-51). Shimon the Hasmonean appointed Ptolemy, son of Abubus, as special military commander for the district of Jericho, and Ptolemy built the Dok fortress (I Macc 16: 11-16).

It seems that the Jordan Valley, and especially Jericho, played a significant role during the rule of Alexander Jannaeus (103-76 BCE). Jannaeus founded Alexandrion (War I, viii: 2), and perhaps laid the foundations of the town of Coreae. According to Strabo (*Geographica* XVI, ii: 40 – Hamilton and Falconer 1903) the Hasmoneans also built the fortresses of Thrax and Taurus in the vicinity of Jericho.

7. The Roman and Byzantine periods (63 BCE-632 CE)

The ER period (63 BCE-73 CE) is characterized by King Herod's actions and the First Jewish-Roman War (The Great Revolt). Herod rebuilt Alexandrion (War I, xvi: 3), greatly developed Jericho, and erected an aqueduct and a palace (War I, xxi: 4). North of the city he established Fasaelis (War I, xxi: 9) and Archelais (see Zertal 2012a: 84-86; sites 34, 111). In 62 BCE Pompey descended from Pehel and encamped at Coraea (War I, vi: 5), which is the "outset of the land of Judah" according to Josephus Flavius. By Pompey's command Aristobulus descended three times from the fortress of Alexandrion to Coraea in order to plead for his servant. This is also the first evidence of the Beit She'an-Jericho road used by Pompey. Gabinius besieged Alexandrion (War I, viii: 4), and supposedly the remnants of the siege from around the fortress can be related to him, as published by Meshel (1989) with a special entry in this volume (Site 165). The events around Alexandrion came to light late in the research: the resulting problem was whether the desert fortresses, including Alexandrion, were an administrative hub, treasuries and a centre for their vicinity (as Tsafirir 1975; Guri-Rimon 1996 and Regev 2000), or palaces serving the rulers (Meshel 2003). It is fitting that the environmental aspect provided by the Survey should be added to the discussion. There is a certain lack of accord between the results of the Survey and historical knowledge. For example, the explanation of the dense habitation grouping around the Sartaba in the LR period is not clear. Also the military structures from the times of Trajan and Hadrian revealed in

the desert fringes north of the Sartaba area, so far lack a historical background.

From the administrative standpoint, the district was divided between the Decapolis (the pact between the ten cities with an alien culture in Jordan, and Beit She'an) and Judea, with the border being Nahal Tirzah. Landscape Unit 27 was perhaps part of the territory of Scythopolis (Beit She'an), belonging to the Decapolis. The narrow zone further south, Landscape Unit 28, was also probably part of the same administrative district, and it seems that most of the population was pagan. According to another division the territory belonged to the toparchy of Jericho and another part (the Sartaba?) to that of Aqrabbim ('Aqraba).

The territory hardly took part, if at all, in the Great Revolt against the Romans (66-73 CE). In the month of Sivan (late springtime) of 68, Vespasian descended from Neapolis to Coraea and stayed the night there (War IV, viii: 1), taking advantage of the good road of Nahal Tirzah. Hence, Coraea was again being considered as a road junction and administrative place, at which it was customary to encamp and conduct negotiations. From there Vespasian continued his journey to Jericho on road B10, along which horticulture and towns flourished.

During the Byzantine period the district was dominated by two cities of substance: Beit She'an and Jericho. The introduction of Christianity, and the many traditions linked to the River Jordan and Jericho, considerably increased the significance of the entire district. For this matter the Onomasticon of Eusebius and two maps (Madaba and Peutinger) add significant information. The linkage between the Madaba Map and the Onomasticon is clear. The Onomasticon notes several sites in the south of the Beit She'an Valley, and especially 'Einim which is close to Shalem, identified in the area of springs south of Tell el-Ridhghah (Site 18). Another site is Beth-Meḥola (Bethmaela) which we identified at Khirbet es-Sakut (Site 32). Between it and Coraea there are no additional sites in the Madaba Map, and the short and not-to-scale distance between the sites in the map should be noted. Two fords of the Jordan are shown here by a quasi-bridge; and Avi-Yonah (1953: 139) notes rightly that the northern one is meant to be the one next to Tell Abu Sus (Site 33). Opposite Coraea is a large circle over the Jordan into which Wadi ez-Zarqa (River Jabbok) empties from the east. The meaning of the circle is unclear, and other rivers (Nahal Tirzah) are unmarked. Next to Archelais is a desert shrub and next to Jericho is a date palm. The continuation northwards from 'Einim has not been preserved. From the sources and the finds it is obvious that Coraea was also an important road junction in this period, although it is marked in the Madaba Map only as a village (two towers with a gate between – Avi-Yonah 1953: 140). In the Peutinger Map the Beit She'an–Jericho road appears in detail (see discussion on roads in Section B: 4).

An additional aspect is connected to the Samaritan rebellions against the Byzantines during the rule of the Emperors Zeno and Justinian in 484, 539 and 555 CE (Avi-Yonah 1956). The monk Malalas tells of the burning of churches in Scythopolis during the Samaritan uprising of 529 (Di-Segni 1988) and their enthronement of Julian. From there the rebellion spread to Neapolis, where churches were set alight and a temporary kingdom was established. Malalas recounts that after the repression of the uprising the Samaritans fled across the Jordan to Trachon and the 'Iron Mountain' next to the River Jabbok (Wadi Zarqa). Their escape route probably passed through the surveyed area, in which they might have had allies.

8. The Early Moslem period and the Medieval era (632-1099 CE)

After the Moslem conquest the districts of the Jordan and Jericho gained great importance. The invasion of the Moslem forces in 634 CE began with three columns, one of them entering via the eastern side of the Jordan, along the King's Highway up to Damascus. From that city they broke through southward to Beit She'an. Here, at Tell el-Ridhghah (Tel Shalem) (Site 18), a decisive battle between the Moslems and the Byzantines took place on 23 January 635, resulting in a Moslem victory. The Moslem force was commanded by Amr ibn al-Aas, afterwards the conqueror of Egypt. The conquered Byzantine population was compelled to pay poll-tax – *Jizya*, and land tax – *Haraaj* (Yekutieli 1971: 207).

During the rule of the Umayyad and Abbasid dynasties the region belonged administratively to Jund al-Urdun (Gil 1981: map p. 77).

The region is only rarely mentioned in the Crusader period. In the Beyer Map (1940: 168) the border between the Principality of Jerusalem and that of Shechem passes near Shiloh further south of the Sartaba to the Jordan. In our surveyed area, Qaraweh (Site 85) is mentioned by the traveller Yacut in 1229 (Le Strange 1890: 480), as a village with facilities for the production of sugar. The district is named *al-Ghōr*, and is mentioned by the Moslem travellers Ibn Fadlallah al-'Omari and Kalkschandi (Beyer 1940: 200). In the Crusader sources the horn of the Sartaba is mentioned in the 14th century CE as 'the large mountain' (Beyer 1940: 200-201).

CHAPTER TWO

THE GEOGRAPHICAL-HISTORICAL
IDENTIFICATIONS*Site 3: Tell Qa'un*

Identification with Jokmeam, a city marking the boundary of Solomon's Fifth District, is suggested: "Baana the son of Aḥilud, in Ta'anach, Megiddo, and all Beit She'an that is beside Zarethan below Jezreel, and from Beth She'an to Abel-Meḥolah, as far as the other side of Jokmeam" (1 Kgs 4: 12). Jokmeam is mentioned twice: once in the quotation above, and the second as a Levite city in Ephraim (1 Chron 6: 53). It was therefore suggested to identify it as Tell eṣ-Šimadi in Nahal Tirzah (Site 84; Mazar 1980a: 226 note 9). This suggestion seemingly relies on the double location of Jokmeam on the Manasseh-Ephraim border (Aharony 1979: 313). However, Mazar-Aharony's suggestion stretches the bounds of the Fifth District about 25 km further south from Beit She'an along the Jordan Valley. Such a boundary is geographically illogical, because it produces an extension including the Third Administrative District from the east. The mention of Jokmeam is also doubtful: in Josh 21: 22 the name Kibzaim appears instead of Jokmeam as a second Levite city in Ephraim. The closeness of Jokmeam to Beth Horon indicates another district entirely. Mazar's conclusion (1980a: 226) regarding the exchange of names does not seem to be convincing. Hence, it is our opinion that Jokmeam in the Levite city list is confused with another city, and the city in the district list should be Abel-Meḥolah.

Another difficulty arising here is the proposition by Alt (1926), Elliger (1930) and Glueck (1951: 419) for identifying Ataroth (Josh 16: 7) on the Manasseh-Ephraim boundary at the same site – Tell eṣ-Šimadi. This proposal extends Ephraim's boundary much further east. This requires that each site has two completely different names at the same period, which is implausible. The town Ataroth has recently been identified in Kh. 'Aujah el-Foqa next to Jericho (Zertal et al. 2009).

In our opinion it is preferable to describe the original boundary as follows: "...from Beit She'an to Abel-Meḥolah, as far as the other side of Jokmeam". This marks the bounds of the district near Beit She'an. If Tell Abu Sus (Site 33) is Abel-Meḥolah, the order of border towns should be: Abel-Meḥolah in the south-east and Jokmeam (Qa'un) in the west. In Qa'un there is a small tell with IA finds. The name was subject to some changes, but the essential consonants remain.

Another option is the identification of Jokmeam as Tell Mukehaz (1) (Site 11), see below.

Additional Bibliography: Kallay 1960; Avi-Yonah 1963: 124; Toews 1992.

Site 11: Tell Mukehaz (1)

This is the second option for the identification with Jokmeam, see the discussion above. The name (note the similarity of the consonants m-k-ah = k-m-a) fits its location and the periods found in the survey.

Bibliography: see Site 3 above.

Site 18: Tell el-Ridhghah (Tel Shalem)

This has been identified, supposedly, with Shalim (Salumia) of the New Testament, near where John the Baptist preached. The place is mentioned twice by Eusebius:

1. "Salēm [III]... eight milestones from Scythopolis, a hamlet in the plain called Salumias" (Taylor 2003: 84).
2. "Ainön (John 3: 23). Near Saleim, where John baptized, as in the Gospel of John. And the site is pointed out even until today 8 milestones south of Scythopolis near Saleim and the Jordan" (Taylor 2003: 29 [see also Aenon]).

According to Van de Velde (Abel 1913: 222) there is a sheikh's tomb in the place named Salim, which might have preserved the ancient name.

Abel proposes three possible sites for the identification of Shalem (see also discussion of Site 23): 'En el-Fātūre, Tell el-Ridhghah or Umm el-'Umdan. Based on the preservation of the name (Sheikh Salim, which is close to the first of the three), and by virtue of the preservation of the remains at the foot of the tell, he accepted Shalem's identification in or near that tell (Abel 1913: 223-224).

Additional Bibliography: Lagrange 1895: 56ff; Reeg 1989: 597-598.

Site 22: Bardaleh

This is identified with Bardalah in the Talmud, mentioned by R. Aḥa Bardela from Rabbi's pupils (Talmud Bavli, Giṭṭin 14a [Epstein 1960: 49]; Sukkah 26a [Epstein 1960: 112]). R. Judah bar Pazzi of Bar Delayya (Talmud Yerushalmi, Besah 4: 5 [Neusner 1987: 103]), Abba Cohen Bardala (Talmud Bavli, Baba Mezia 10a [Epstein 1960: 54]; Zebhim 33b [Epstein 1960: 166]; Talmud Yerushalmi, Peah 4, Halakhah 2 [Guggenheimer 2000: 164]) and R. Ya'aqov Bar Abayey de Bardalah (Talmud Yerushalmi, Shevi'it 2, Halakha 4, Gemara [Melinovich

and Goldstein 2007: xi/1]). Concerning the people of Bardalah, it was said that they are not particular about their *prusah* (slice of bread) (Talmud Yerushalmi, Erubin 6: 8 [Neusner 1998: 145]).

Additional Bibliography: Vilnay 1968: 89; Reeg 1989: 149-150.

Site 23: 'Ein ed-Deir

A possible identification with Aenon of the New Testament, appearing also in the Madaba Map (Avi-Yonah 1953: 139-140). In Aenon (Ainain – John 3: 23) John baptized his followers. Eusebius locates the place at eight Roman miles distance south of Beit She'an (Taylor 2003: 29 [Ainon], 84 [Salēm]). The lady traveller Aetheria (385 CE) – also known as Egeria, Etheria or Sylvia – mentions the Salem Valley as rich with plantations. According to Abel (1913: 222-224), the group of springs south of Tel Salem was identified as the place where John the Baptist spoke his last words. After being victimized by Herod Antipas, John was baptised in the vicinity of the springs of el-Fatour. During the Byzantine era Salem was also identified as Salem of Melchizedek (Gen 14: 18), and its name was preserved in a nearby fortress named Sedima or Salumias. A church on a tell in the valley was dedicated to Melchizedek. In the nearby 'Garden of Saint Jean' was a spring that was used for baptism during the Easter holiday. Today, says Abel, it is impossible to locate the remains.

Additional Bibliography: Conder and Kitchener 1882: 247; Lagrange 1895: 56.

Site 30: Tell el-Hammeh

The site had been identified by Albright (1924-1925; 1925a) with the Hamath appearing in the Seti I list. We have two sources: Seti's victory stele from Beit She'an (ANET: 253-254) and the topographical lists from Karnak in Egypt.

The stele, discovered by the Pennsylvania expedition and published by Rowe (1929; 1930), presents the sequence of events as follows: "On this day (year one, 3rd month of season 3, day 10) one came to speak to his Majesty as follows: "The wretched foe who is in the town of Hamath is gathering to himself many people while he is seizing the town of Beth-Shan. Then there will be an Alliance with them of Pahel. He does not permit the Prince of Rehob to go outside. Thereupon his Majesty sent the first army of Amon, (named) "Mighty of Bows," to the town of Hamath, the first army of Re, (named) "Plentiful of Valor," to the town of Beth-Shan, and the first army of Seth, (named) "Strong of Bows," to the town of Yanoam. When the space of a day had passed, they were overthrown (the rebels) to the glory of his Majesty, the King of Upper and Lower Egypt: Men-maat-Re; the Son of Re: Seti Mer-ne-Ptah, given life." (ANET: 253-254).

In the second source, Seti's reliefs on the north wall of the temple at Karnak,

appear the names Pahel – [p3-h]y-[r3] – No. 49, Hamath – h3-m[y]-t – No. 50, Beit She'an – b3-ts[3]-r[3] – No. 51 and Yanoam – y-[nw-c3-mw] – No. 52 (Ahituv 1979: 66 and in it Noth's analysis).

Albright's identification fits the location of the site (south of Beit She'an and Tel Rehov) to the find at the tell (LBA) and the preservation of the name. However, Wilson remarks in the opening to his translation in ANET (p. 253 note 5), that the name Hamath does not necessarily refer to this town, as otherwise it should have read 'the wretched foe from the town of Hamath'. In his opinion it is likely that the intent is to any town in the north, because Seti sends his army northwards to Yanoam; yet it seems that the main attestations opt in favour of the above identification. The excavation results, not reaching the strata from Seti's period, do not change the identification.

Additional Bibliography: Reeg 1989: 257-258.

Site 32: Khirbet es-Sakut

We are inclined to accept the identification with Beth Maela (Taylor 2003: 27 [Abelmaelai/ Abelmaula]) and Biblical Succoth. Eusebius (Taylor 2003: 27 [Abelmaelai/ Abelmaula]) defines Biblical Abel-Meholah in his description: "Abelmaelai (I Kgs 4:12). A city of one of Solomon's princes, from which Elisha came. It is now a village in Aulon, ten milestones from Scythopolis, and now called Bethmaela. There is also an Abelmea on the way from Neapolis to Scythopolis."

Zobel (1966) proposed identifying this site as Khirbet es-Sakut. The proposition, which is very reasonable, relies both upon the identification of Biblical Abel-Meholah as the nearby Tell Abu Sus (Site 33) and the existence of abundant Byzantine finds in this large site.

Guérin (1969: 269-274) tries to combine the name Sakut with various mentions of Biblical Succoth. The mention in Genesis 33: 16-18 speaks of the Succoth Valley, situated well south of Khirbet es-Sakut. The mentions in Josh 13: 24, 27 are also irrelevant because they speak clearly about Jordan. The nearest Succoth is mentioned in the account of Gideon pursuing the Midianites in Judg: "And Gideon came to the Jordan and crossed over, he and the 300 men who were with him, exhausted yet pursuing. So he said to the men of Succoth, please give loaves of bread to the people who follow me, for they are exhausted, and I am pursuing after Zevh and Zalmunna, the kings of Midian" (Judg 8: 4-5). This Succoth is likely to be located east of the River Jordan, due to the mention of the Jordan crossing and the relation to the continuation of the verse to the town of Penuel which is across the Jordan.

Guérin also proposes to link Succoth of the copper tool episode (I Kgs 7: 46) and Khirbet es-Sakut. This linkage, whose geographical basis is difficult, is

based on the mention of Zarethan in I Kgs 4: 12, in the description of the Fifth District. However, Albright (1929: 33) has already convincingly shown that this Zarethan is in the wrong place, and seems to have been moved a long way northwards from its original location in the mid-Jordan Valley. For all these reasons Guérin's identification should not be accepted, and the name Succoth is probably late or irrelevant. As to the archaeological find, the site fits all the proposals.

Additional Bibliography: Glueck 1943; Reeg 1989: 451-452.

Site 33: Tell Abu Sus

The proposed identification is with Abel-Meḥolah, mentioned in the Bible in three references:

1. In the book of Judges, in the Gideon story: "And the army fled as far as Beth-Shittah toward Zererah, as far as the border of Abel-Meḥolah, by Tabbath" (Judg 7: 22). The main discussion concerns the meaning of "as far as". Glueck (1943: 12) proposed, based upon the expression in Deut 2: 36, that it means the Abel-Meḥolah plateau overlooking the valley of Tabbath. Loewenstamm (1972: 38) surmised that the intention is to a 'river bank'. In the whole episode the flight of the Midianites was described as from west to east, and the capture of the Jordan fords by Ephraim at Gideon's command. Among those fords ("as far as Beit-Barah" – Judg 7: 24) there is no mention of Abel-Meḥolah; Nonetheless, Tzori (1967) relied on the fords, close to Tell Abu Sus, repeating Mittmann and Zobel's proposal to identify Abel-Meḥolah in this place.
2. In the description of Solomon's Fifth District boundary the place appears once more: "...Ta'anach, Megiddo, and all Beit She'an that is beside Zarethan below Jezreel, and from Beit She'an to Abel-Meḥolah, as far as the other side of Jokmeam" (I Kgs 4: 12). Albright (1924-1925: 44-47; 1925b: 32ff) proposed to emend the text as follows: 'Ta'anach, Megiddo as far as the other side of Jokmeam and all Beit She'an below Jezreel from Beit She'an to Abel-Meḥolah that is beside Zarethan', a reasonable proposition.
3. In the course of Elijah's narrations in I Kgs 19:16, 19, the place is mentioned as follows: "And Jehu the son of Nimshi you shall anoint to be king over Israel, and Elisha the son of Shaphat of Abel-Meḥolah you shall anoint to be prophet in your place" (I Kgs 19: 16), and afterwards: "So he departed from there and found Elisha the son of Shaphat, who was ploughing with twelve yoke of oxen in front of him" (I Kgs 19: 19). This requires the place to be in an agricultural area, wide enough for extensive ploughing, but there is no geographical correspondence.

The identification of Abel-Meḥolah at Tell Abu Sus was proposed by Zobel (1966), Tzori (1967) and Mittmann (1970: 128, 270), contradicting the previous identification of Abel-Meḥolah by the British Survey at Tell Abu-Sifry (Tell el-Ḥilu), also supported by Albright (1924-1925: 44-47; 1925b: 32ff), Alt (1928: 42ff), and Abel (1967, II: 234), apparently based on the Onomasticon of Eusebius. According to this definition (No. 158) "There is now a village called Bethmaela (Bethmaula) in the Aulon [of which we have spoken above], ten miles from Scythopolis...".

Glueck proposed that the site is across the Jordan, but his reasoning is unacceptable. In Adelman's (1992) opinion, in a preliminary summary of the matter, Abel-Meḥolah should be west of the Jordan, about 20 km south of Beit She'an, and next to a water source or river (according to Albright's conventional interpretation of the word 'נַחַל' – "a stream or a rivulet of water" – Mazar 1972a), and agricultural land. The identification with Tell el-Ḥilu is inadmissible due to the absence of Byzantine remains at the site (Zertal 2008: site 96). The place does not fit well agriculturally, because it is situated in a narrow wadi (see Loewenstamm's opinion, 1972).

At first Zertal (1996: 105) suggested identifying Kh. Mhalal, next to Tell el-Ḥilu, as Abel-Meḥolah, but after the survey at Tell Abu Sus he changed his mind. The main arguments for the latter, put forward by Zobel (1966), are as follows: Primarily, Eusebius' definition of a Byzantine site some 20 km south of Beit She'an with a name similar to that of Abel-Meḥolah is accepted. Secondly, the milestones revealed during the surveys of Tzori and Mittmann testify, according to Zobel, to Via Romana leading southwards from Beit She'an to Jericho. The milestone with no inscription, found by Mittmann close to Kh. es-Sakut, testifies to the tenth mile by distance. Zobel surmises that the road and the milestones are the basis for Eusebius' definition. Hence, the site of Bethmaela is supposed to be in this vicinity (here being given a detailed description of Tell Abu Sus). The Byzantine site itself is identified, in his opinion, as Kh. es-Sakut (Site 32), which is 1.2 km southwest of Tell Abu Sus. An abundance of LR and Byzantine pottery has been found in the latter. In Zobel's opinion, the inhabitants of Abel-Meḥolah (or Beth-Meḥolah) descended from the tell once there was no more need for the protection provided by its height. There is sense in Zobel's argument, except perhaps for the fact that the size of the settlement in Abel-Meḥolah does not match the description of the town.

We shall try to summarize the geographical and archaeological data:

1. Gideon's pursuit of the Midianites. According to the context, it is feasible to identify the route of the chase from 'Ein-Harod – the Spring of Harod (Judg 7: 1) to the bank of the Jordan. Beth-shittah, Zererah, Beit-Barah and Tabbath are unknown, yet it is obvious that they are in the vicinity of

the Jordan. From the above, the assumption that the term 'river bank' is related to the Jordan is logical.

2. King Solomon's Administrative Districts. According to the geographical logic, the description of the boundary is from west to east – from Ta'anach and Megiddo to Beit She'an. If Albright's assumption that Zarethanah is not in the right location (because Zarethan is located in the mid-Jordan Valley) there is sense in the order of sites: 'below Jezreel' could be the areas north of the tell; the meaning of 'all Beit She'an' is probably all the area belonging to the city-state of Beit She'an, and see also the discussion below. 'Jokneam' has not been firmly identified, but we propose to identify it in the area of Qa'un.
3. The Elijah and Elisha episode. There is little information in this episode, and it is possible to deduce from it only that there were major agricultural areas in the district. Glueck's opinion, according to which Abel-Meholah's location is deducible by Elijah's walking direction from Damascus does not seem to be well founded.

Additional Bibliography: Mittmann 1970: 128, 220; Avi-Yonah and Yeivin 1973; Tzori 1977: site 56.

Site 65: Bedhat esh-Sha'ab

A likely identification option (by Dror Ben-Yosef) is the tent of Adam. In Psalms 78: 60 it is written "So that he forsook the tabernacle of Shiloh, the tent which he placed among men". 'Men' here is a translation of the Hebrew word 'Adam', and since this phrase was built as a rhetoric parallelism, Adam can be understood as a place name, as is the word Shiloh.

The location and the town of Adam are probably related to the Damia Bridge and the Jordan crossings (Josh 3: 16; II Chron 4: 17; I Kgs 7: 46; Psalms 83: 11; Hosea 6: 7-8). The place is mentioned, although vaguely, in relation to important events occurring in it. Quoting Mazar (1986: 170-171): "specifically interesting are the verses in Psalms 78: 59-60: "When God heard *this*, he was wroth, and greatly abhorred Israel: So that he forsook the tabernacle of Shiloh, the tent *which* he placed among men" and also Psalms 68: 18: "Thou hast ascended on high, thou hast led captivity captive, thou hast received gifts for men [in the Hebrew Bible: in Adam - A.Z.]." Instructive is the proposal that the intention in these verses is to the town of Adam, a sanctified place from antiquity in the proximity of the Jordan crossings, the sanctuary of the tabernacles at the time of the settling of children of Israel in the Jordan plain, in which gifts were presented to God (Goitein 1947) and perhaps that to this sanctified

place refers also the tradition about the “altar of imposing size”, erected by the tribes of the eastern side of the Jordan “... over against the land of Canaan, in the borders of Jordan...” (Josh 22: 11), probably in the place of the river crossings, which according to the author (Josh 22: 21ff) was not meant for sacrifice and offerings except serving as a witness between them and the tribes of Israel on the west side of the Jordan, with their centre being at Shiloh”.

This was close to the town of Adam, where there was probably a cultic centre, rising to prominence simultaneously with the decline of Shiloh. This ancient centre is mentioned in various sources, and there is no reason to doubt its existence. During two seasons of excavations in Bedhat esh-Sha’ab the date of the site was determined roughly from the end of the 12th to the 8th centuries BCE. The likely function of the place was also determined to have been a place of assembly, and perhaps a cultic site. It is possible that this site was one of the centres which correspond to the Biblical traditions.

Additional Bibliography: Kutscher 1935; Mazar 1972b: 109; 1986: 170; Aharony 1979: 313, 335-336.

Site 73: el-Makhrug (2)

Identification proposed with Zarethan (Josh 3: 16; I Kgs 4: 12; 7: 46). This town in the Jordan plain has not been identified.

Bibliography: Albright 1925a-b; Glueck 1943; Aharony 1962: 11; Oded 1971; Mazar 1972b.

Site 84: Tell eṣ-Ṣimadi

Identification proposals are Jokmeam, Ataroth and Beth-Barah.

1. Jokmeam: the town appears in I Kgs 4: 12 in the description of the boundary of the Fifth District: “Baana the son of Aḥilud, in Ta’anach, Megiddo, and all Beit She’an that is beside Zarethan below Jezreel, and from Beit She’an to Abel-Meḥolah, as far as the other side of Jokmeam”. Hence, Jokmeam marks the eastern or southern boundary of the district; therefore, Aharoni (1962: 111 and note 8), Mazar (1980a: 226 and note 9) and others suggested identifying it at Tell eṣ-Ṣimadi. Backing the proposal is the double mention of Jokmeam as one of the Levite towns of Ephraim (I Chron 6: 53); hence, it has been concluded that the town should be on the Manasseh-Ephraim boundary, and the nearest spot is Tell eṣ-Ṣimadi. However, Mazar’s proposal pulls the boundary southward along the Jordan, and has no geographical logic. The Third District practically reaches the Jordan, and there is no reason for the boundary to turn southwards. The name also has not been preserved in the place,

although the archaeological find enables any of the options.

2. Ataroth: Glueck (1951: 419) proposed that the tell is one of the border points between Manasseh and Ephraim: "and the boundary goes from there to the sea. On the north is Michmethath. Then on the east the boundary turns around toward Taanath-shiloh and passes along beyond it on the east to Janoah, then it goes down from Janoah to Ataroth and to Naarah, and touches Jericho, ending at the Jordan" (Josh 16: 6-7). Janoah was identified by many with Kh. Yanun east of Shechem. From it the boundary went to Ataroth, Naarah and came out to Jericho and to the Jordan. If Ataroth was in Tell eṣ-Šimadi, the Manasseh-Ephraim boundary stretches in a somewhat peculiar way: from Shechem to Yanun, on the hilly plateau by 'Aqraba, and from there returning to Wadi Far'ah to reach Tell eṣ-Šimadi. The geographical logic requires the descent of the boundary along Wadi Afjeam and Wadi Ahmar south-eastward in the direction of Jericho.

The discovery of the site in 'Aujah el-Foqa (Zertal et al. 2009) allows it to be identified as Ataroth, and it seems that a reasonable solution has been found to the problem.

3. Beth-Barah. Ben-Yosef (2009) proposed that the tell is Beth-Barah, which appears in the war between Gideon and the Midianites (Judg 7-8). The Midianites who were defeated in the Jezreel valley retreated towards the River Jordan near Abel-Meholah (identified as Tell Abu Sus, see Site 33 above), and Gideon asked for the support of the people of Ephraim: "And Gideon sent messengers throughout all Mount Ephraim, saying, come down against the Midianites, and take before them the waters unto Beth-Barah and Jordan" (Judg 7: 24).

According to Ben-Yosef Tell eṣ-Šimadi fits the following geographical and archaeological criteria that make the identification with Beth-Barah possible:

- a. The site is situated in the centre of the western Jordan Valley in the vicinity of the area of the tribe of Ephraim.
- b. The identification of "waters" (Judg 7: 24), with Wadi Far'ah only 500 m to the north of the site.
- c. The site is very close to Tell Damia (identified as "the city of Adam"), where the Midianites were finally defeated (Psalms 83: 11).
- d. IA pottery was found in the site.

Additional Bibliography: Abel 1913: 227; 1967, II: 241-242; Schumacher and Steuernagel 1924; Albright 1925b; Alt 1926; 1928: 41; Elliger 1930; Kallay 1960; 1971; Mazar 1960: 202; 1972b; Franklyn 1992; Toews 1992.

Site 85: Qarawet et-Tahta

The identification with Coraea has been verified. The town is mentioned during Vespasian's expedition to Judea in 63 BCE. Josephus Flavius writes: "Indignant at this behavior, and yielding to the urgent entreaties of Hyrcanus and his friends, Pompey started in pursuit of Aristobulus, with the Roman forces and a large contingent of Syrian auxiliaries. Passing Pella and Scythopolis, he reached Coreae, at which point a traveller ascending through the interior enters the territory of Judaea. There he heard that Aristobulus had taken refuge in Alexandreion, one of the lavishly equipped of fortresses, situated on a high mountain, and sent orders to him to come down" (War I, vi: 5).

Coraea appears also in the Madaba Map (Avi-Yonah 1953, leaf 1: 140). It is marked to be along the Jordan, between 'Ainain (Ainon/Aenon) near Saleim' and Archelais/Fasaelis. Coraea in the Madaba map is a 'village', marked by two towers with a gate between them, but Avi-Yona notes that this manner of detailing is sometimes the outcome of a shortage of space in the mosaic rather than the site's real details.

The town at the foot of Tell eṣ-Ṣimadi fits – by location, archaeological finds and the preservation of the name (Qaraweh) – the town of Coreae. It seems that the place was planned and contained columned structures, some of which have been found in the Survey.

Conder and Kitchener (1882: 395-396) proposed locating Archelais in the place; however its preferred identification is with Kh. Beiyudhat (Zertal 2012a: site 111), some 15 km to the south.

Keruthin (variant: Karuhim) is a place named in the Mishna: "From where did they bring the wine? Keruthin and Hattulin" (Kodashim, Menahoth 8: 6). It has been suggested that this is another name for Coraea (Reeg 1989: 577-578). **Additional Bibliography:** Abel 1913: 227; 1967, I: 399; 1967, II: 34; Avi-Yonah 1963: 124; Möller and Schmitt 1976: 130.

Site 173: Sartaba

The accepted identification with Alexandrion has been confirmed. This is a fortress built at the summit by Alexander Jannaeus. A proposal to identify it with Zarethan has not been accepted.

Bibliography: Schmidt 1910; Moulton 1936; Abel 1967, II: 63; Möller and Schmitt 1976: 12; Reeg 1989: 552-553.

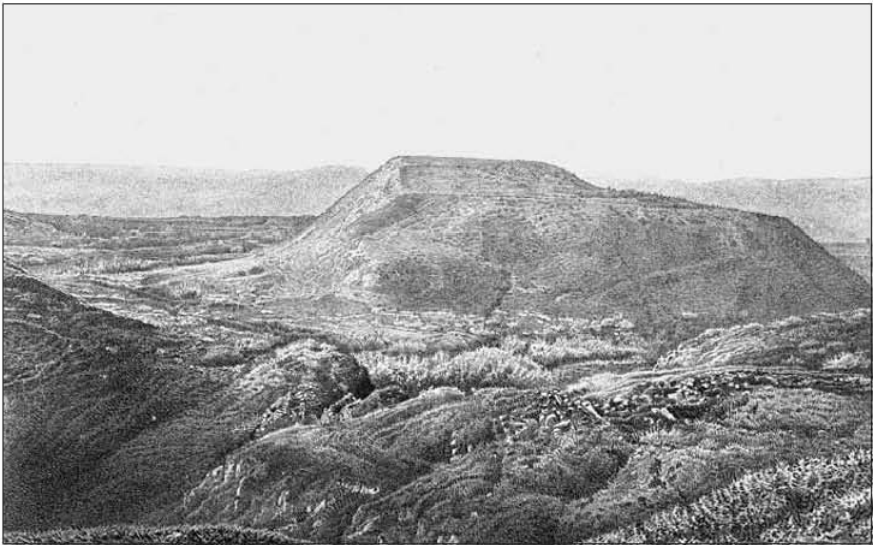
PART TWO

DESCRIPTION OF THE SITES

CHAPTER THREE

THE SOUTHERN BEIT SHE'AN VALLEY

LANDSCAPE UNIT 27



32. Beit She'an – ancient tell, etching (Conder and Kitchener 1882: facing p.107).

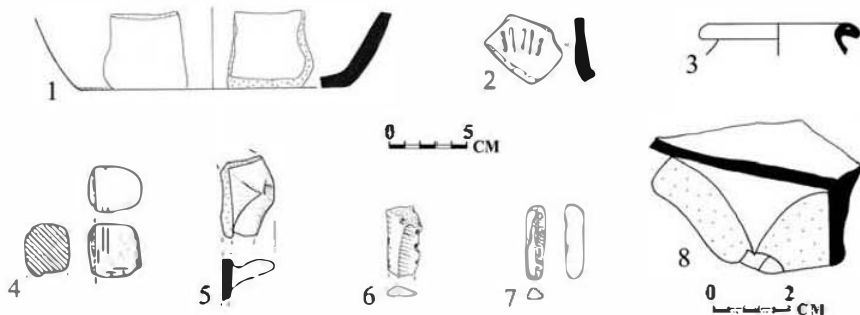
Site 1: 19-2●/31/2
WADI QA'UN (1)

Israel grid: 1931/2●11	Soil quality: 8
UTM grid: 731●/5881	Cultivation: field crops
Elevation: 25 m b.s.l., ● m a.s.a.	Cisterns: none
Name: nearest place	Water source: Qa'un springs (132), 1 km distant
Site type: small, spread-out settlement	Road: Shechem–Beit She'an (B7), 5●● m distant
Area: 3.5 dunams (35●● sq. m)	Visits: Nov. 1988, repeated visits in 2●●1; 253 sherds
Topography: valley fringes	
Rock type: alluvium cover	
Soil type: colluvial-alluvial	

A site on the northern bank of Wadi Qa'un, situated about 1 km west of Qa'un Springs and south of Wadi Shubash. The wadi at the site is broad and shallow with many ravines, but with rather steep banks. This topography served the inhabitants for utilizing both the area above the wadi, and the wadi banks themselves for agricultural proposes.

The site is situated at the confluence of two small tributaries of Wadi Qa'un. The place may have had an enclosure wall, built from especially large stones, descending to the wadi and encircling the settlement. In the part above the wadi bank, remnants of structures survived – fieldstones and pebble-built walls.

Most of the site area is located within a cultivated field. The building stones were cleared and moved southward to the edge of the slope. Many sherds were found in this area. At the site's western side is a large round structure about 12



33. Finds from Wadi Qa'un (1) – all IB: 1. Base, gr-dk brn; 2. Sherd, incised dec, gr; 3. Jug, dk gr; 4. Grinding stone/weight, chalk; 5, 8. Folded 'enveloped' ledge handles, dk gr; 6-7. Flint blades.

m in diameter, whose connection to the site is not clear.

This is an IB settlement, one of a cluster of sites in the region. The site's unique wall, almost unknown in this period (but see another fortified site in the region in Kh. el-Meiyiteh - Zertal 2008: site 90), requires additional research.

Pottery: Intermediate Bronze – 100%.

Flint: 1 item, see Appendix A.

Additional surveys: None.



Site 2: 19-20/41/5

KHIRBET QA'UN (1)

Israel grid: 1941/2016

UTM grid: 7320/5885

Elevation: 45 m b.s.l., 10 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: tell

Area: 6.5 dunams (6500 sq. m)

Topography: hilltop at valley fringes

Rock type: Dead Sea group

Soil type: colluvial-alluvial

Soil quality: 9

Cultivation: field crops

Cisterns: none

Nearest water sources: Qa'un springs
(132), at the site

Nearest road: Shechem–Beit She'an
(B7), next to the site

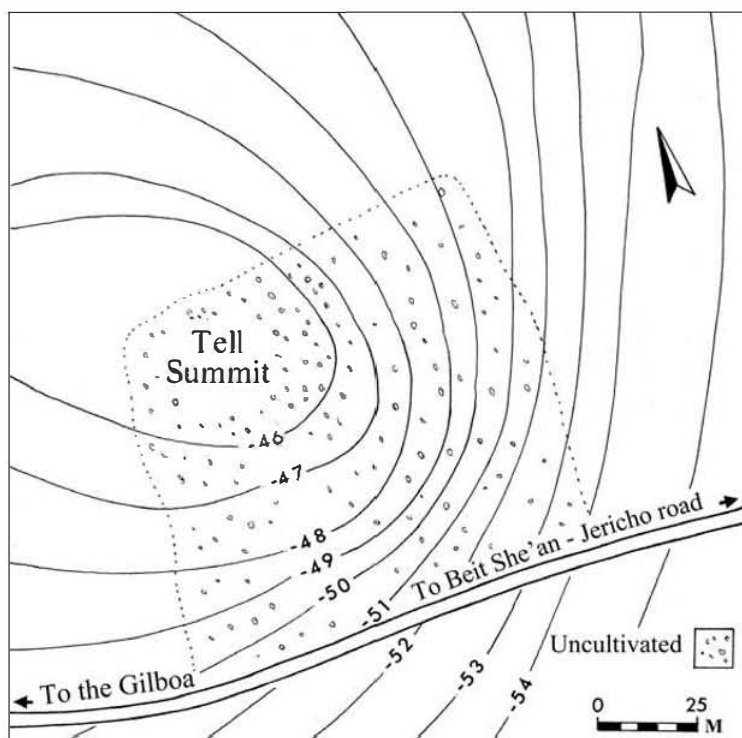
Visits: Nov. 1988, repeated visits
during 2001; 65 sherds

A low tell on the northern bank of Wadi Qa'un, north of Qa'un springs and Tell Qa'un. Nearby to the south is the road from the Jordan Rift Valley road to Nahal Bezeq, and north of the site extend the cultivated and irrigated fields of the southern Beit She'an Valley.

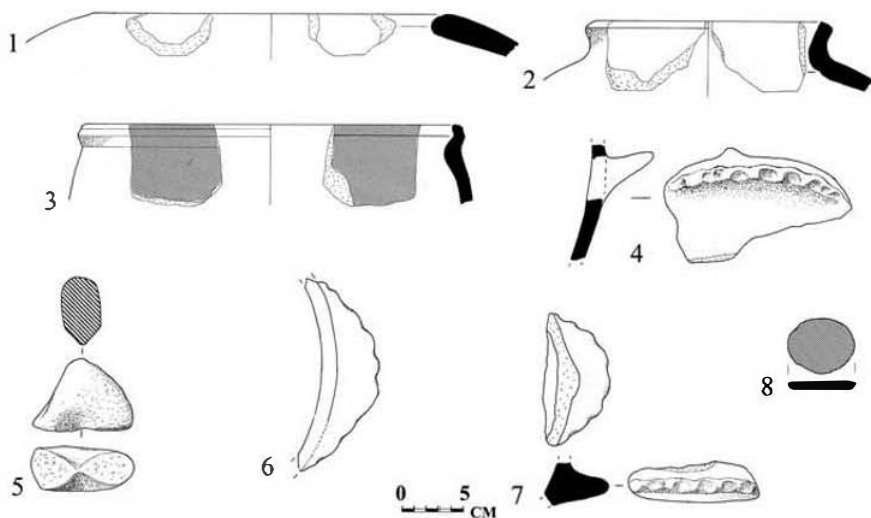
Half the site sprawls over a rocky step in the upper part of the southern slope of the tell, above the bed of Wadi Qa'un. In this area are remnants of ancient construction. The other part (the western one) is now within a cultivated field. In the centre of the tell are six rock-cut caves, some of which served as burial caves. They have been robbed, and a few Byzantine sherds are scattered outside.

Many EB I sherds are scattered around the site area and the cultivated field nearby. About 20 rock-cut round installations of varying dimensions, including basins and cup marks, were found in the rock surfaces near the burial caves.

The tell is part of the rich complex of the Qa'un sites clustered around the springs. It is mainly an EB I settlement, whose inhabitants used the nearby cemetery (Site 4).



34. Plan of Khirbet Qa'un (1).



35. Finds from Khirbet Qa'un (1), all EB I: 1. HM, dk brn, gr; 2. Jar, lt brn; 3. Krater, lt brn, rd slip outside and inside; 4, 6-7. Ledge handles, dk brn; 5. Stone with biconical perforation; 8. Lid.

Pottery: Early Bronze I - 90%; Byzantine - 10% (only in burial caves).

Flint: 177 items, Epipalaeolithic and Early Bronze I (see Appendix A).

Stone: 13 fragments (see Eitam 2005: 656).

Additional surveys: none.

Bibliography: Bar 2014a: site 1.



Site 3: 19-20/41/1

TELL QA'UN

Israel grid: 1944/2014

UTM grid: 7323/5884

Elevation: 45 m b.s.l., 30 m a.s.a

Name type: ancient, but not on map

Site type: tell

Area: 7 dunams (7000 sq. m)

Topography: hilltop at edge of ridge

Rock type: Dead Sea group

Soil type: colluvial-alluvial

Soil quality: 7

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: 1

Nearest water source: Qa'un springs
(132), 300 m distant

Nearest road: Shechem–Beit She'an
(B7), next to the site

Visits: March 1986, repeated visits and
plan - 2001; 148 sherds

A low tell at the edge of the ridge descending northward to Wadi Qa'un, about 400 m west of Kh. Qa'un (3) (Site 6) and about 2.5 km north-north-west of Bardaleh. The tell is isolated on the east and west by ravines through which the tributaries of Wadi Qa'un flow. In the north it descends to the deep Wadi Qa'un, and in the south a gently sloping saddle descends to the cultivated plain north of Bardaleh.

Only a few remnants of a wall encircling the tell's summit are visible. Within the compound are one- (or two-) roomed structures, of which only segments of walls built of fieldstones and pebbles survive. Inside the structure is the opening of a cistern.

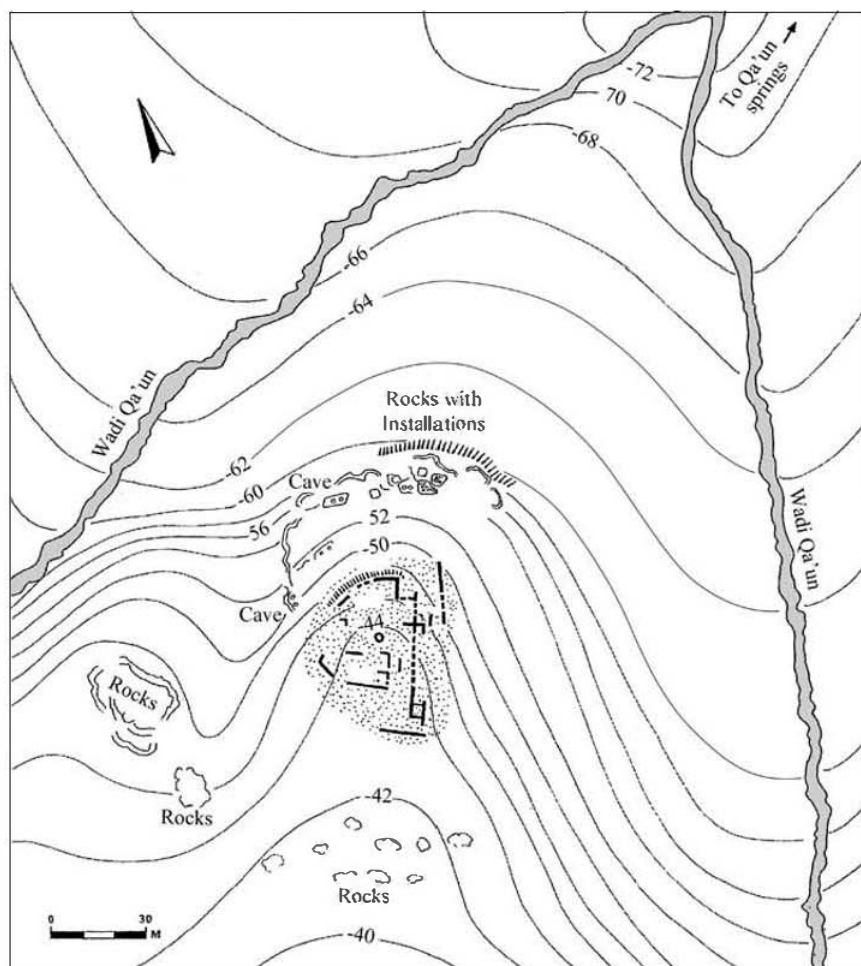
About 40 m north of the summit, down the slope, is a group of rocks encircling the hill. Among the rocks are caves with collapsed ceilings and numerous rectangular rock-cuttings, amongst which are significant elements of wine-presses, as well as basins and many cup marks of varied sizes and depths. In the saddle south of the tell is a rock-cut basin, 80 cm in diameter.

At the top of the site stood a large structure, possibly a fort guarding the springs.

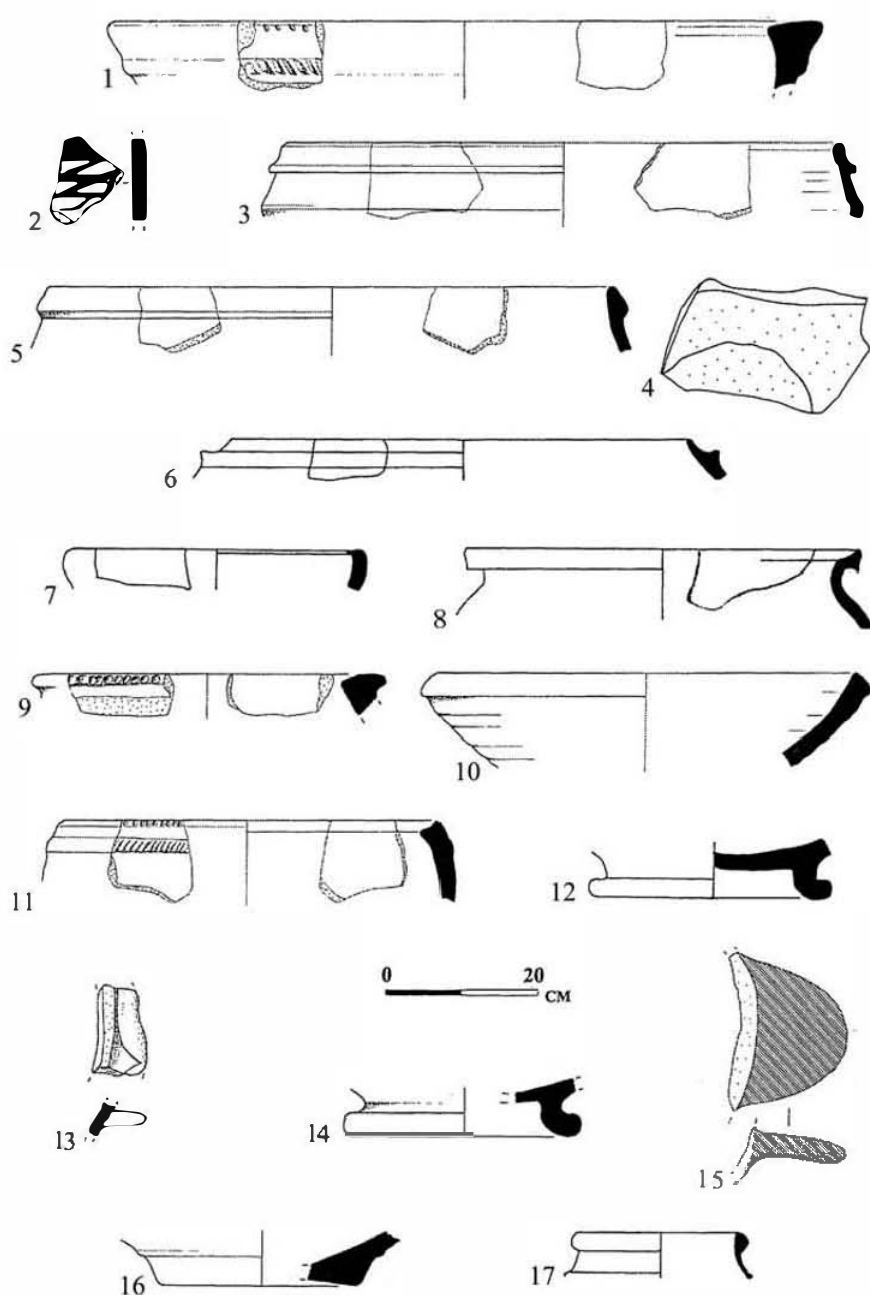
Robinson mentioned the place upon his visit to the Beit She'an Valley in 1852, describing it as: "We could here see Wadi Khushneh coming down

through the mountains, in a northeast course; and thus forming an almost direct route from Tubas to Beisan. North of it, another valley, Wadi Kubosh [should have been Shubash, A. Z.]...just under the southeastern flank of the mountains proper of Gilboa. In its mouth is a fountain, and a ruin called Ka'un" (Robinson 1970, III: 314).

In January 1907, E. W. G. Masterman visited the place on his way from Nablus to Safed, and wrote: "We now turned our steps in this direction, descending a small shallow valley. At 4.50 we passed a considerable mass of ruins on our right, known as Rejum Ka'un, and in a few minutes reached a small spring arising in a marshy valley bed. The squalid village of Ka'un lay a few yards to our east on the wadi. We ascended the north bank and entered the plain." (Macalister and Masterman 1907: 100).



36. Plan of Tell Qa'un, 2001.



37. Pottery from Tell Qa'un: 1. Krater, buff, rope orn, well fird, Chal; 2. Sherd, band slip, rd on cream, EB I; 3, 5-6. CPs, dk brn, mica, Ir I; 4. Folded ledge handle, dk gr, IB; 7. Bowl, lt brn, Ir I; 8. CP A, dk brn, Ir I; 9. Bowl, pk, rope orn, MB II; 10. Bowl, dk gr, Pers; n. Krater, yel, EB; 12, 14. 'Mortaria' bases, lt gr, well fird, Pers; 13. Folded ledge handle, IB; 15. Ledge handle, lt brn, cream slip, EB I; 16. Base, dk gr, Ir II; 17. Jar, buff, Ir II.



38. Tell Qa'un, view to the south-west, 1986. The tell is indicated by an arrow. In the foreground is Wadi Qa'un, and in the background to the right is 'Iraq el-Hamam ridge and Wadi Shubash (Nahal Bezeq).

Pottery: Chalcolithic – 5%; Early Bronze I – 15%; Early Bronze II – 20%; Intermediate Bronze – 10%; Middle Bronze IIb – 15%; Late Bronze – 2%; Iron I – 10%; Iron II – 10%; Persian – 10%; Hellenistic – 3%.

Stone: 57 tools and installations (see Eitam 2005: 658-663).

Identification: see Chapter 2.

Additional surveys: None.

Additional Bibliography: Conder and Kitchen 1882: 227; Bar 2014a: site 4.

Site 4: 19-20/41/2

CEMETERY OF QA'UN

Israel grid: 1942/2013	Soil quality: 2
UTM grid: 7320/5883	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 50 m b.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: none
Name type: given by the survey team	Nearest water source: Qa'un Springs
Site type: cemetery	(132), 300 m distant
Area: 10 dunams (1 ha)	Nearest road: Shechem–Beit She'an
Topography: slope	(B7) next to site
Rock type: Dead Sea group	Visits: Feb. 2001, repeated visits in
Soil type: colluvial-alluvial	2001; 200 sherds

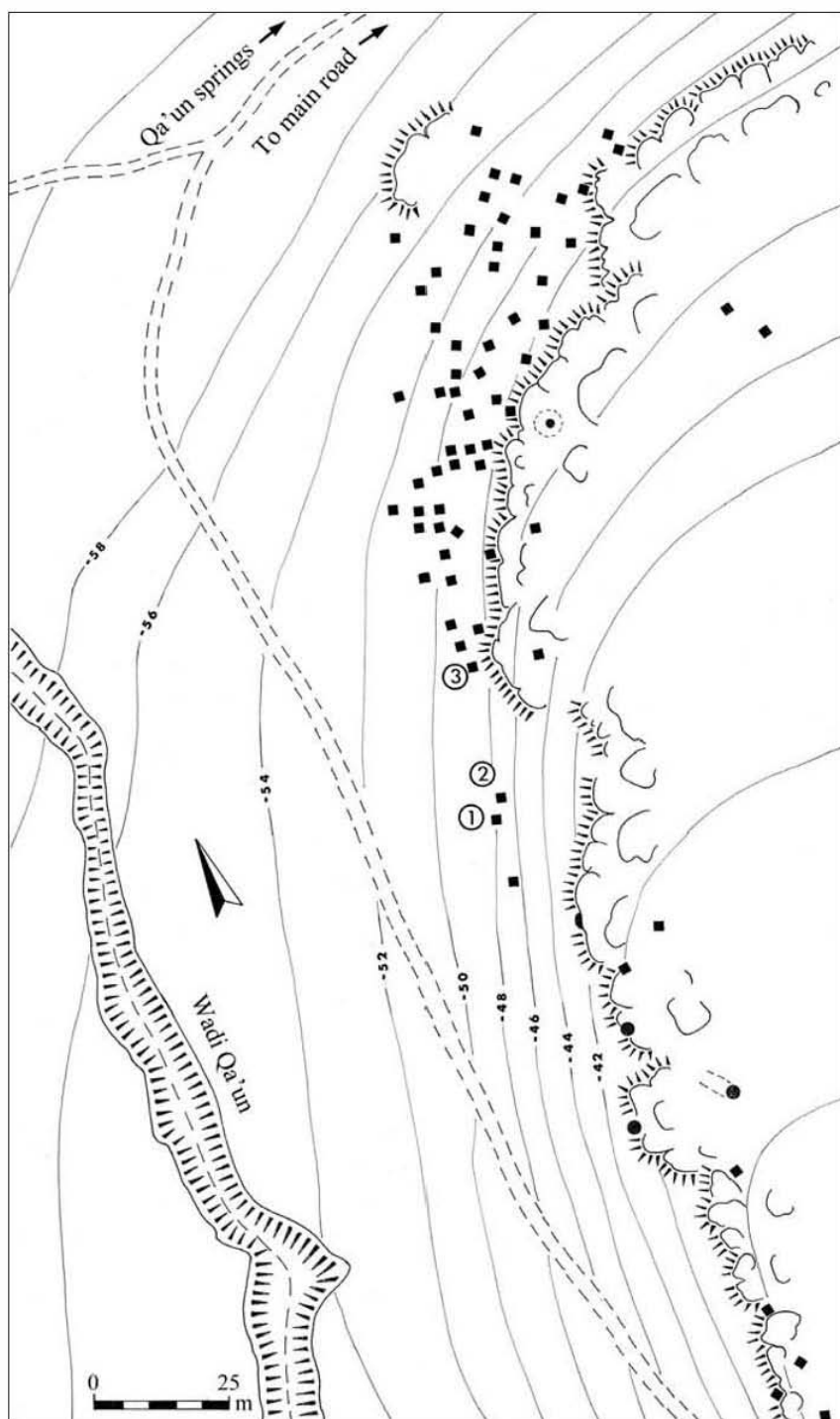
A large cemetery, undergoing a long process of robbing, at the southern fringes of Wadi Qa'un and east of Tell Qa'un.

A large looted cemetery was found about 300 m down the escarpment descending to Wadi Qa'un in the east. The looting began in the 90s, and has been continuous since (in our previous visits in the area in 1986-7, the pillaging had not yet started).

The openings of about 200 tombs were exposed beneath a layer of rocks at the top of the slope. Most of them are shaft tombs with a wide shaft about 2 m deep. The majority of the shafts are rectangular, measuring 1 m long by 0.8 m wide (There are also some square ones). The shafts lead into rock-cut burial chambers via short vaulted tunnels. The burial chamber ceilings are also generally vaulted – they are usually about 2 m long by 1 m wide by 1 m high. One double tomb was found, with two burial chambers. Another type in the site is the tunnel-shaped cave tomb, with an opening cut into the slope and the entrance slanted or horizontal. The tomb contents were robbed and scattered, therefore we were unable to determine their inner composition.

Some of the tombs are arranged in rows, 2–3 m apart. The tomb robbers understood this arrangement, and managed to locate the graves by trial and error. Near the tombs are large debris heaps containing large fragments of vessels broken during the looting. It seems that the cemetery was a regional one serving various nearby settled sites for a long period.

In this large regional cemetery, which was in use for a very long time, tombs were reused, with enlargements and changes. The wide variety of ceramics in the cemetery is noteworthy. Prominent for example, are IB red-painted vessels of the 'Megiddo Family'.



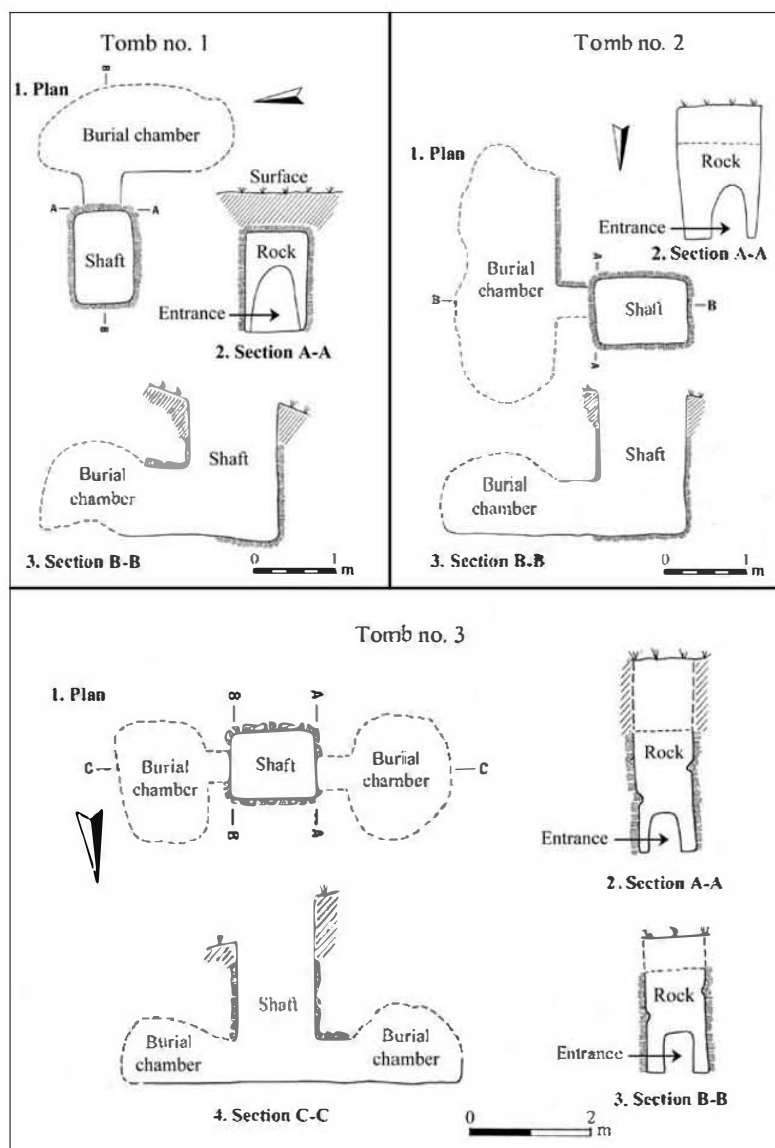
39. Plan of the cemetery of Qa'un, 2001.

Pottery: Chalcolithic (?) – 3%; Early Bronze I – 12%; Early Bronze II-III – 28%; Intermediate Bronze – 22%; Middle Bronze II – 15%; Iron I – 8%; Iron II – 5%; Persian – 7%.

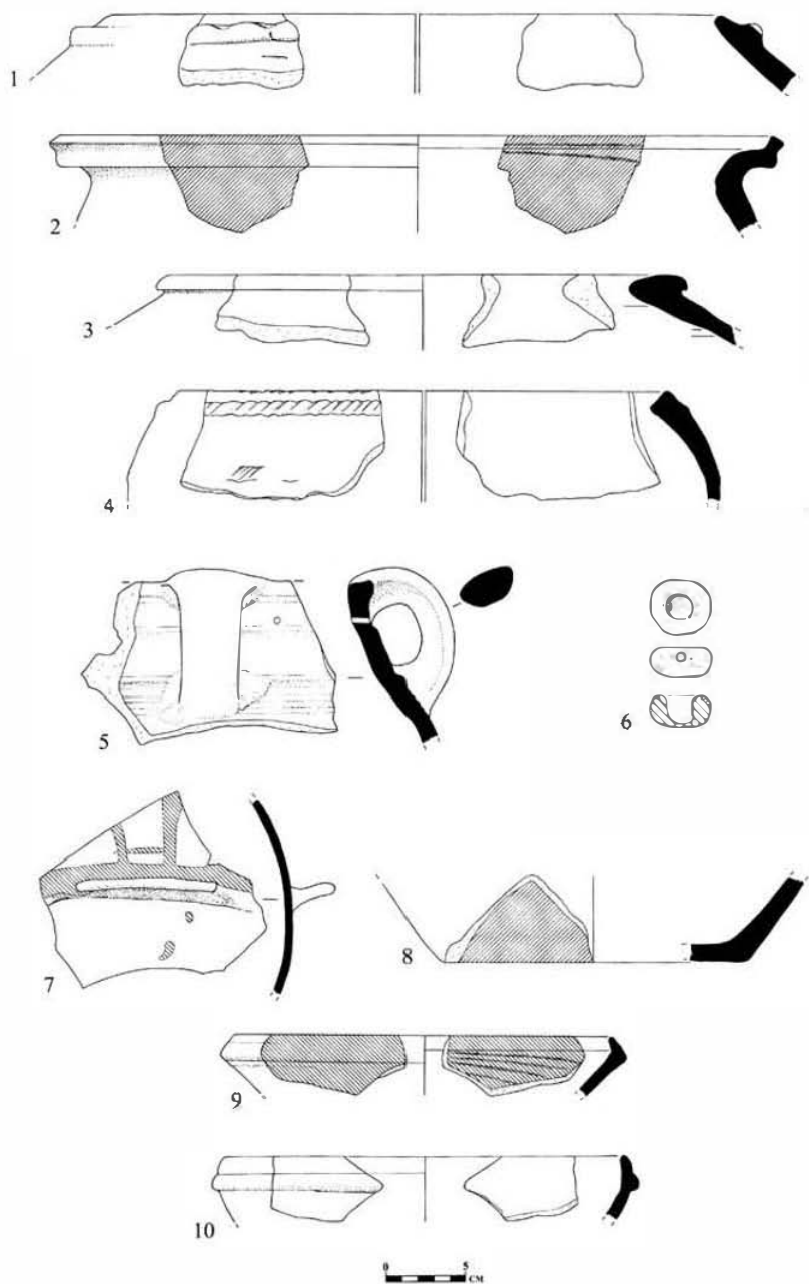
Flint: 45 items, probably Chalcolithic, see Appendix A.

Additional surveys: none.

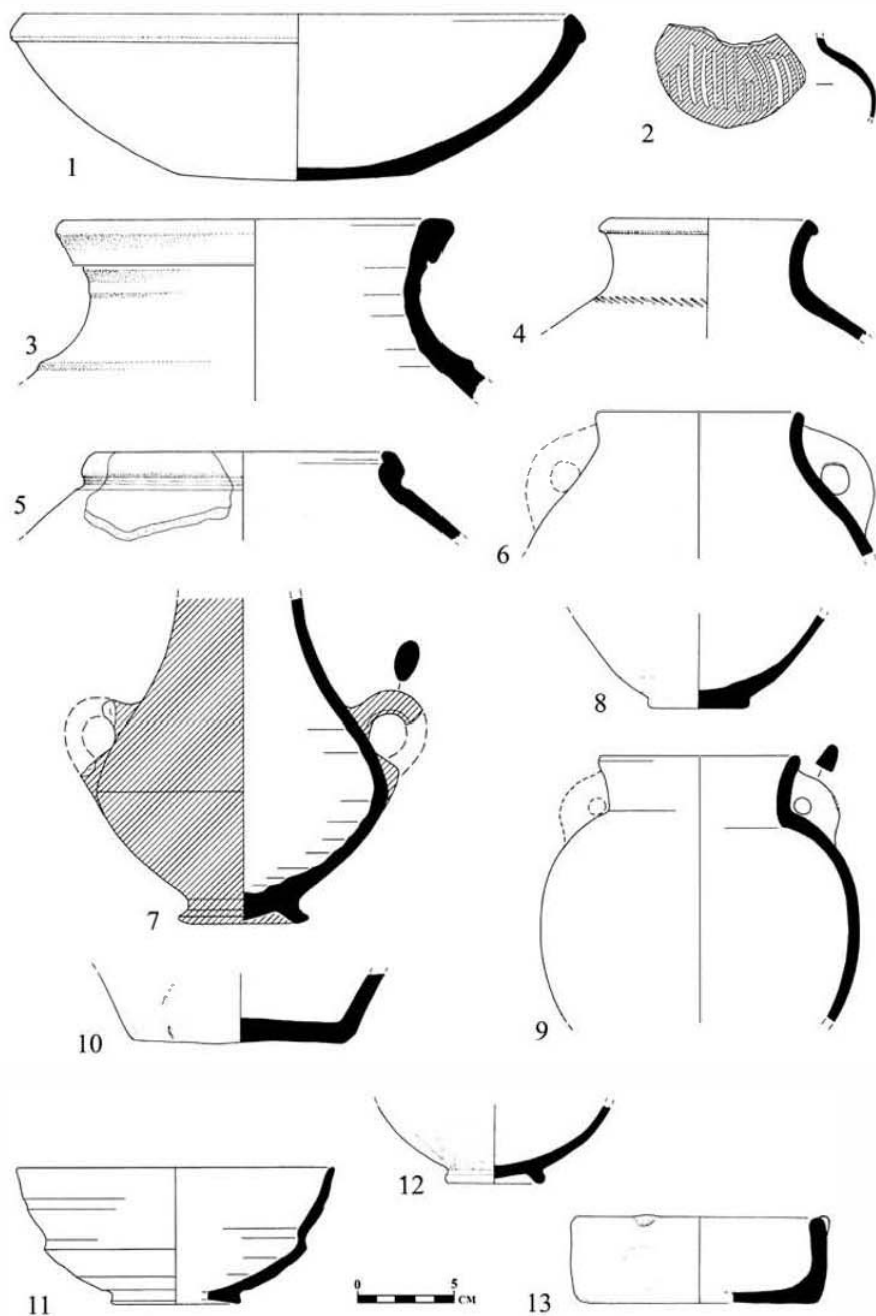
Additional Bibliography: Bar 2014a: site 3.



40. Plan, view and cross-sections of tombs 1-3 in the cemetery of Qa'un. The tomb numbers are marked in the general plan (Fig. 39).



41. Finds from the cemetery of Qa'un, part 1: 1. HM, yel, EB; 2. Krater, buff, rd slip and burnished, EB; 3. Krater, gr, EB I; 4. HM, buff, rope orn, EB I; 5. Krater, buff, Ir II; 6. Dagger's ball shaped knob, limestone, IB; 7. Ledge handle, rd, 'Megiddo Family', IB; 8. Base, buff with rd slip, EB; 9. Platter, rd slip, EB II-III; 10. Krater, pk, MB II.



42. Pottery from the cemetery of Qa'un, part 2: 1. Bowl, dk gr, well fired, Pers; 2. Sherd, rd band slip, IB; 3. Jar, buff, MB II; 4. Jar, buff-gr, IB; 5. Krater, buff, Ir II; 6, 8-9. Amphoriskoi, buff, IB; 7. Jar, rd slip, LB; 10. Base, buff, EB; n. Carinated bowl, buff, LB; 12-13. Bowls, LB.



43. The cemetery of Qa'un, aerial view to the east, 1999. The robbed tombs are at bottom right. On the left is the road leading from the Jordan Valley road to the Gilboa Range (M. Weinberg).



Site 5: 19-20/41/3

KHIRBET QA'UN (2)

Israel grid 1942/2014

UTM grid 7321/5883

Elevation: 45 m b.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: large

Area: 60 dunams (6 ha)

Topography: plain

Rock type: alluvial floodplain

Soil type: colluvial-alluvial

Soil quality: 7

Cultivation: field crops

Cisterns: none

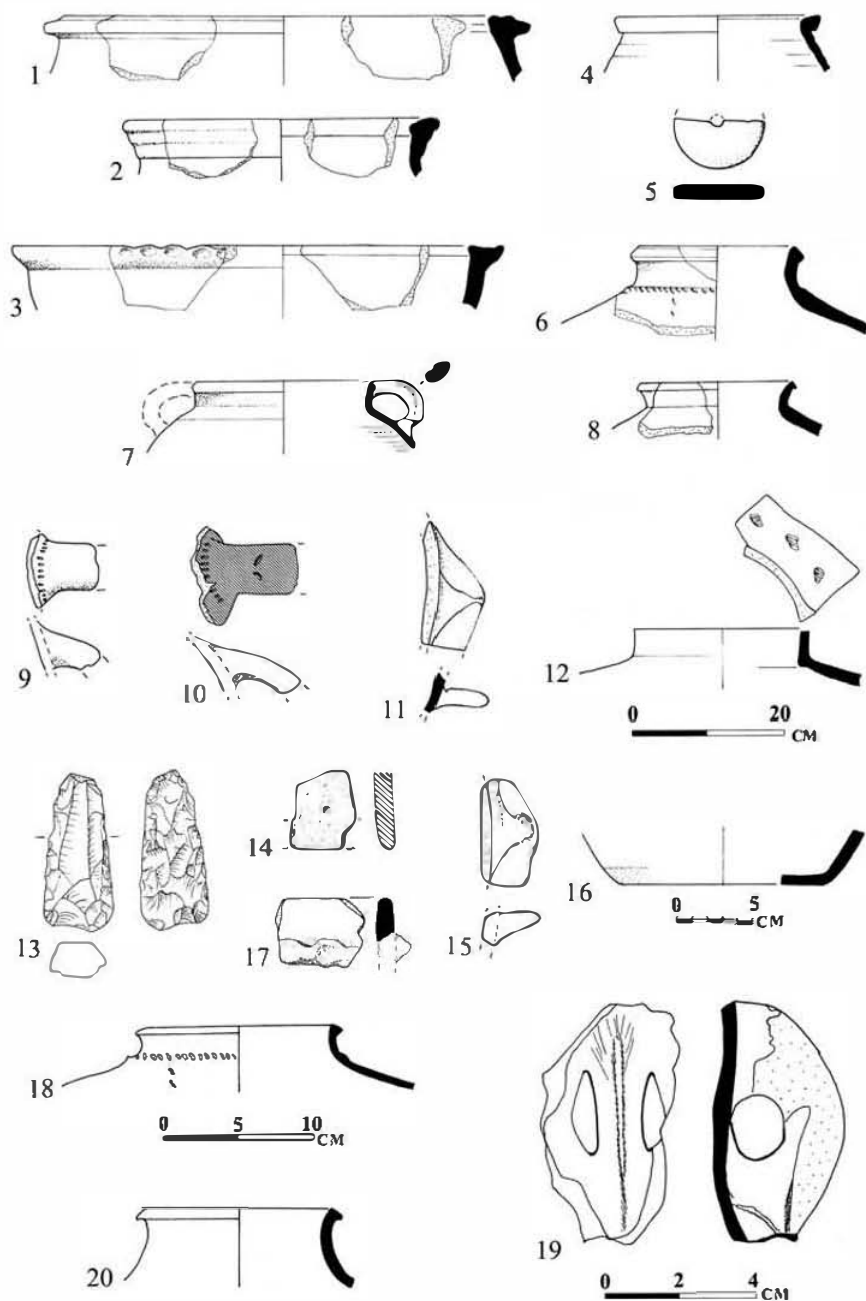
Nearest water source: Qa'un Springs
(132), 300 m distant

Nearest road: Shechem–Beit She'an
(B7), next to the site

Visit: Nov. 1988; 176 sherds

This is a large site in a field, south-west of Tell Qa'un. In the west the site borders the valley separating it from Tell Qa'un, and in the north it borders Wadi Qa'un. It is about 2 km distant from the Beit She'an-Jericho road to the west.

In the plain, within currently cultivated fields, considerable concentrations of building stones and sherds were found. Worked basalt stones, many grinding stones and similar objects were also found. Especially noteworthy are 20–25



44. Finds from Khirbet Qa'un (2): 1. Krater, gr, IB; 2. Jar, pk, MB II; 3. Krater, rope orn, brn, IB; 4, 6, 8, 12. Jars, buff, IB; 5, 14. Stone/pottery weights, IB; 7. CP, brn, ER; 9-11, 15, 19. Handles, IB; 13. Adze, flint, Chal; 16. Base, gr, IB; 17. Rope orn, gr, IB; 18, 20. Jars, gr, IB.

stone basins, made of large stones with conical holes. The upper diameter of the holes is about 20 cm.

The site's houses seem already to have been dismantled in ancient times (Rom-Byz?). This dismantling was possibly connected to the need to cultivate the fields. There are many prominent heaps of cleared building stones.

This large site was probably a central settlement in a complex of IB sites in the area.

Pottery: Chalcolithic – 10%; Intermediate Bronze – 84%; Middle Bronze II – 3%; Early Roman – 3%.

Flint: 4 items, possibly Chalcolithic and Intermediate Bronze, see Appendix A.

Stone: 207 tools and installations (see Eitam 2005: 663, 667-669, 671-678).

Additional surveys: none.

Bibliography: Bar 2014a: site 2.



Site 6: 19-20/41/4

KHIRBET QA'UN (3)

Israel grid: 1944/2015

UTM grid: 7323/5884

Elevation: 70 m b.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient, and on map

Site type: large, an abandoned Arab village

Area: 90 dunams (9 ha)

Topography: hill spur in valley fringes

Rock type: alluvial floodplain

Soil type: colluvial-alluvial

Soil quality: 7

Cultivation: field crops (partial)

Cisterns: at least 40

Nearest water source: Qa'un Springs (132), at the site

Nearest road: Shechem–Beit She'an (B7), next to the site

Visits: Nov. 1988, Feb. 2001; 88 sherds

A large site in the southern fringes of Wadi Qa'un, which empties into Nahal Bezeq, in the centre of the fertile plain between the 'Iraq el-Ḥamam ridge and the Jordan Valley road, and about 2.5 km north of the village of Bardaleh.

The site spreads over a broad spur along Wadi Qa'un, generally orientated west to east. The site is restricted by ravines in the west and east, and along it are several hillocks. The spur is cut by a small ravine which also descends to Wadi Qa'un. Over the surface of the spur and slopes are scattered many structures, as described below (from east to west):

1. The eastern part: at the east of the spur, next to ravine no. 1 (Fig. 45), is a large courtyard structure measuring 40×40 m. In the structure's



45. Aerial view to the east of Kh. Qa'un (3), 1997. The ravine to the left of the site is Wadi Qa'un (M. Weinberg).



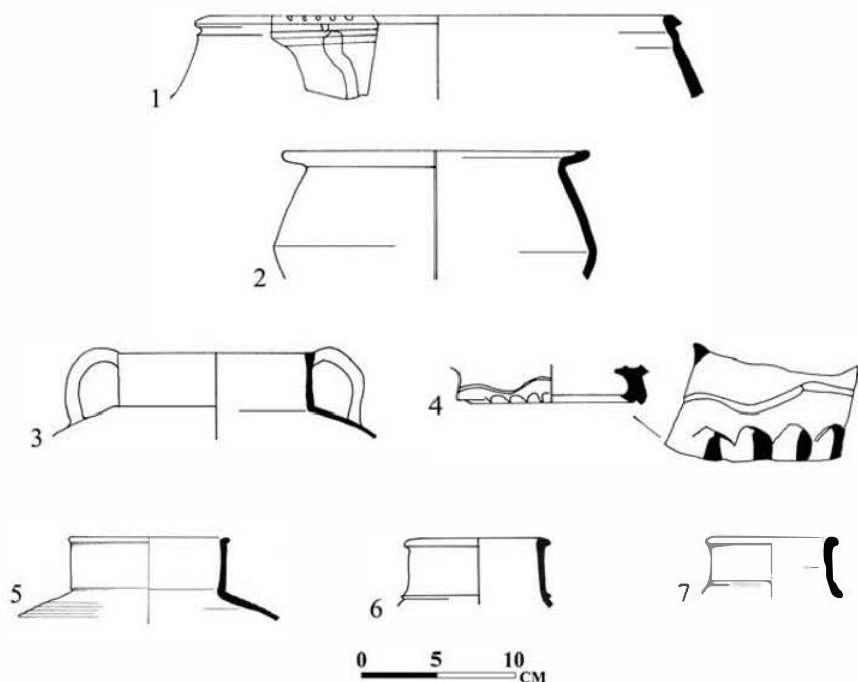
46. Kh. Qa'un (3), looking south-west from Wadi Qa'un, 1986. At left is ravine no. 1.

southern part is a line of three rooms. South of the structure are several large courtyards with straight walls. These courtyards, resembling pools or enclosures, also stretch to the south-west.

Over the eastern spur and in ravine no. 2 in the western part is another group of about 30 structures. All the structures are of local fieldstones, most of them standing up to 1 m high. The openings have been preserved, and also in many cases the wall foundations, which were built of large stones. It is assumed that these foundations belong to an earlier period than the one in which the structures were in use (Rom-Byz?). Close to many of the structures are quarried caves which served as cellars or animal pens.

2. The western part (west of ravine no. 2) on the summit is another concentration of 20-30 structures of similar style. Here caves are abundant, and almost every structure is next to a cave.

This seems to be the location of the Arab village of Qa'un, appearing as a village in the British Survey and British Mandate 1:100,000 scale maps, and which was



47. Pottery from Kh. Qa'un (3): 1. Krater, dk gr, plastic dec, MA; 2. Bowl, brn, LR; 3. CP, brn, LR; 4. Bowl base, dk gr, plastic dec, MA; 5-7. Jars, lt brn, well fired, LR and Byz.

probably deserted after 1967. It is described by the British Survey as “Khurbet Kaa'un is a place of the same character, with mud hovels among ruins, and caves also inhabited. The place has the appearance of an ancient site and a fine spring (Conder and Kitchener 1882: 227).

Vilnay (1968: 354) states: “An Arab village in the slopes of Samaria mountains...The origin of its name is not known. At the slopes of the village are a spring - 'Ein Qa'un, and a river - Wadi Qa'un.”

Ilan (1973: 345) offers the following tradition: “Here was a poor village: its inhabitants deserted it because of plague (and the proximity to the Israeli border), and moved to Bardaleh.”

Pottery: Late Roman – 17%; Byzantine – 45%; Early Moslem – 10%; Middle Ages – 10%; Ottoman – 18%.

Additional surveys: none.



Site 7: 19-20/31/1

WADI QA'UN (2)

Israel grid: 1935/2014

UTM grid: 7314/5883

Elevation: 25 m b.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.

Name type: local

Site type: large

Area: 20 dunams (2 ha)

Topography: valley fringe

Rock type: Dead Sea group

Soil type: alluvium

Soil quality: 9

Cultivation: field crops

Cisterns: none

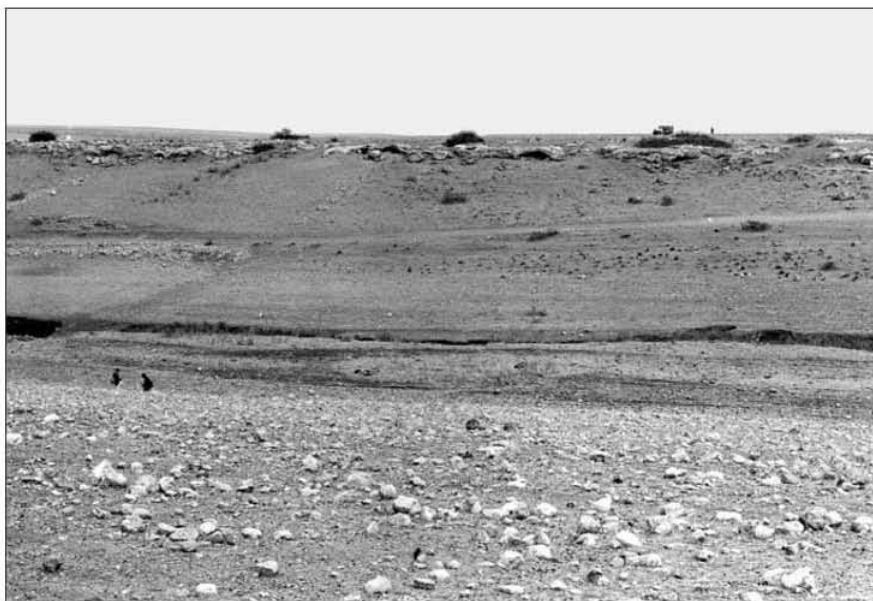
Nearest water source: Qa'un Springs
(132), 500 m distant

Nearest road: Shechem–Beit She'an
(B7), 1 km distant

Visit: Dec. 1988; 22 sherds

A site at the northern fringes of Wadi Qa'un, about 2.5 km north-west of Bardaleh. The scatter of structures still visible situated on the high northern slope of Wadi Qa'un is about 20 m wide. Most of these structures, situated in what is presently a cultivated field, were destroyed during earth-moving. The building stones were piled up on the wadi bank, and there are many sherds in the field.

The original settlement may have extended north-westward. The site's houses were spread in separated small clusters, several tens of metres apart along a strip above the river bed.



48. Wadi Qa'un (2), view westward, 1988.

Pottery: Intermediate Bronze – 76%; Late Roman – 8%; unidentified – 16%.
Additional surveys: none.



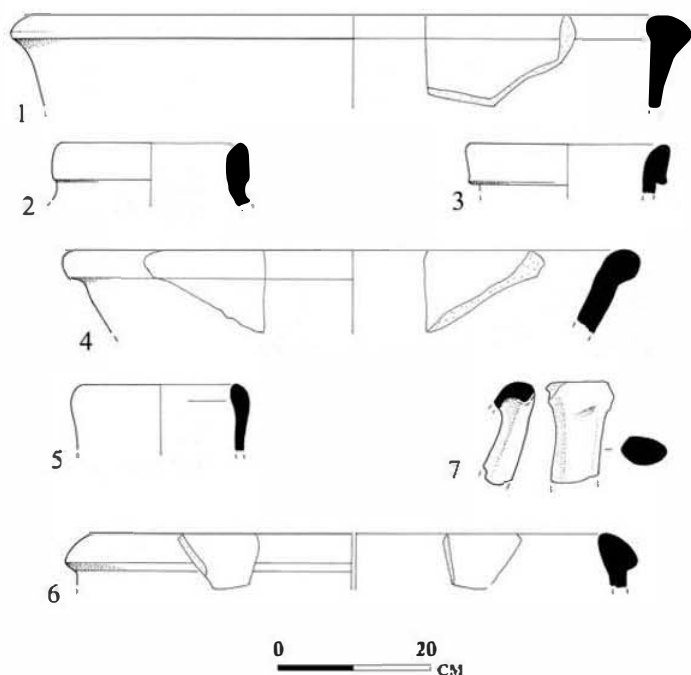
Site 8: 19-20/51/2

KHELLALYEL MADKHUL (2)

Israel grid: 1954/2012
 UTM grid: 7330/5882
 Elevation: 100 m b.s.l., 5 m a.s.a.
 Name type: local
 Site type: medium size
 Area: 5.5 dunams (5500 sq. m)
 Topography: spur
 Rock type: Lisan Formation
 Soil type: alluvium

Soil quality: 4
 Cultivation: none
 Cisterns: none
 Nearest water source: 'Ein Mukehaz
 (159), 1 km distant
 Nearest road: Jericho–Beit She'an
 (B10), 1 km distant
 Visit: Dec. 1989; 50 sherds

This is a site on a wide uncultivated spur, descending eastward to the Jordan Valley. It is situated about 1 km west of Tell Mukehaz (1) and 2 km north of



49. Pottery from Khellalyel Madkhul (2): 1, 4. Kraters, lt gr, EM; 2-3. Jars, gr, Pers-Hel; 5. Jar, Ott?; 6. Krater, lt gr, well fired, Pers; 7. 'Pan' handle, brn, Byz.

Bardaleh. Next to the site is a local confluence of two streams, part of the ravines in the Bardaleh plain.

A few remains of wall sections have been preserved on the summit, and mainly in its south-western part. There are considerable concentrations of sherds over the entire area, indicating that the site's houses were probably dismantled and their stones taken for the construction of the village of Bardaleh.

This was a medium-sized EM village, belonging to the 'Ein Mukehaz settlement complex.

Pottery: Persian - 4%; Hellenistic - 4%; Byzantine - 6%; Early Moslem - 84%; Ottoman - 2%.

Additional surveys: none.

Site 9: 19-20/51/1

KHELLALYEL MADKHUL (1)

Israel grid: 1955/2010

UTM grid: 7334/5880

Elevation: 100 m b.s.l., 10 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: small

Area: 3 dunams (3000 sq. m)

Topography: low spur

Rock type: Lisan Formation

Soil type: alluvium

Soil quality: 7

Cultivation: field crops

Cisterns: none

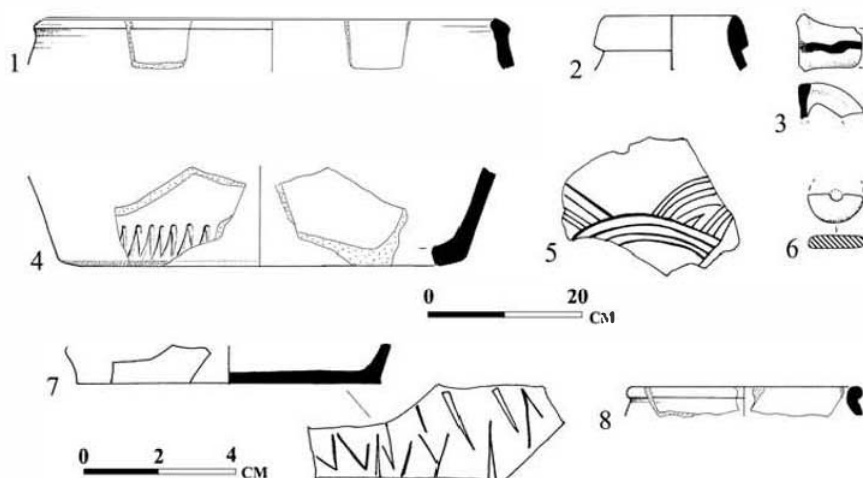
Nearest water source: 'Ein Mukehaz
(159), 1 km distantNearest road: Shechem–Beit She'an
(B10), 1 km distant

Visit: Dec. 1989; 77 sherds

A site on an uncultivated low wide spur sloping eastward to the Jordan Valley, 1 km west of Tell Mukehaz (1); situated in the wide hilly area between Bardaleh and Wadi Qa'un.

Considerable concentrations of large and varied sherds have been found over the spur. Except for a single wall, no architecture survives, and it seems that the building stones were dismantled and taken to nearby Bardaleh.

This was a small Persian-Hellenistic period village connected to the 'Ein Mukehaz complex.



50. Finds from Khellalyel Madkhul (1): 1. Krater, dk brn, Ir I; 2. Jug, gr, Pers; 3. Handle, brn, ER; 4-5, 7. Jar bases and sherds with incisions, gr, IB; 6. Stone weight, IB; 8. Amphoriskos, buff, Hel.

Pottery: Intermediate Bronze – 5%; Iron I – 5%; Persian – 40%; Hellenistic – 40%; Early Roman – 10%.

Additional surveys: none.



Site 10: 19-20/61/1

‘EIN MUKEHAZ

Israel grid: 1963/2013

UTM grid: 7342/5883

Elevation: 135 m b.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: small

Area: 1 dunam (1000 sq. m)

Topography: hilltop in a plain

Rock type: Dead Sea Group

Soil type: alluvium

Soil quality: 8

Cultivation: field crops

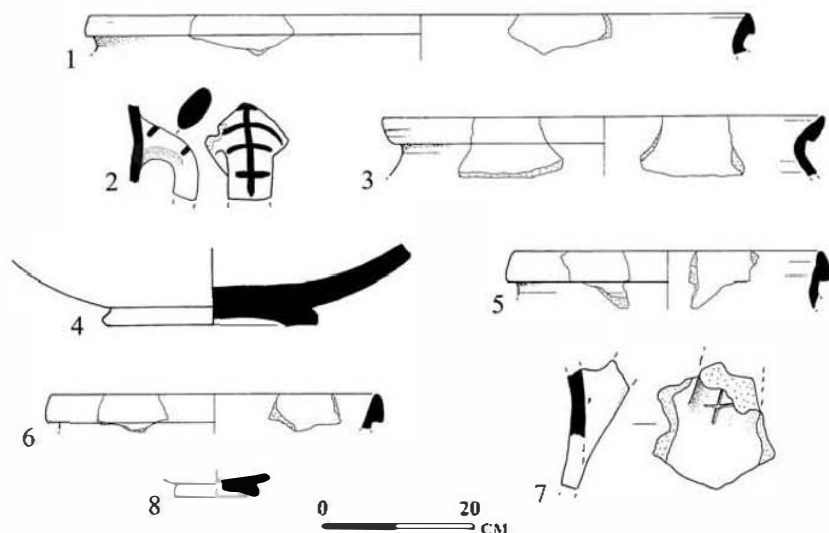
Cisterns: none

Nearest water source: ‘Ein Mukehaz
(159), 300 m distant

Nearest road: Beit She’an–Jericho
(B10), 300 m distant

Visit: Dec.1988; 60 sherds

A small site on a low hilltop at the head of small ravine in the plain of Bardaleh, about 2 km north-north-east of this village, and about 300 m west-north west



51. Pottery from ‘Ein Mukehaz: 1, 3, 5-6. CPs, types A and B, dk gr, mica, well fired, LB-Ir I; 2. Jar handle, rd dec over cream, buff, LB; 4. Bowl base, buff, well fired, LB; 7. Potter's mark on handle, brn, Ir I; 8. Juglet, brn, well fired, LB.

of Tell Mukehaz (1), 'Ein Mukehaz, and the Beit She'an–Jericho road.

A few wall remains, building stones and abundant pottery were found in an area of several hundred square metres which has undergone deep ploughing and bulldozing. IA I cooking pots Types A and B, and LB painted sherds including disc bases are prominent.

A small settlement existed in the place, almost certainly connected to Tell Mukehaz (1). The deep ploughing and cultivation destroyed it completely.

Pottery: Late Bronze – 20%; Iron I – 80%.

Additional surveys: Kohn-Tavor 2010: site 97; 2012a: site 97.



Site 11: 19-20/61/2

TELL MUKEHAZ (1)

Israel grid: 1966/2011

UTM grid: 7344/5881

Elevation: 140 m b.s.l., 15 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient and on map

Site type: small tell

Area: 3 dunams (3000 sq. m)

Topography: valley

Rock type: Dead Sea Group

Soil type: alluvium

Soil quality: 9

Cultivation: field crops

Cisterns: none

Nearest water source: 'Ein Mukehaz
(159), at the site

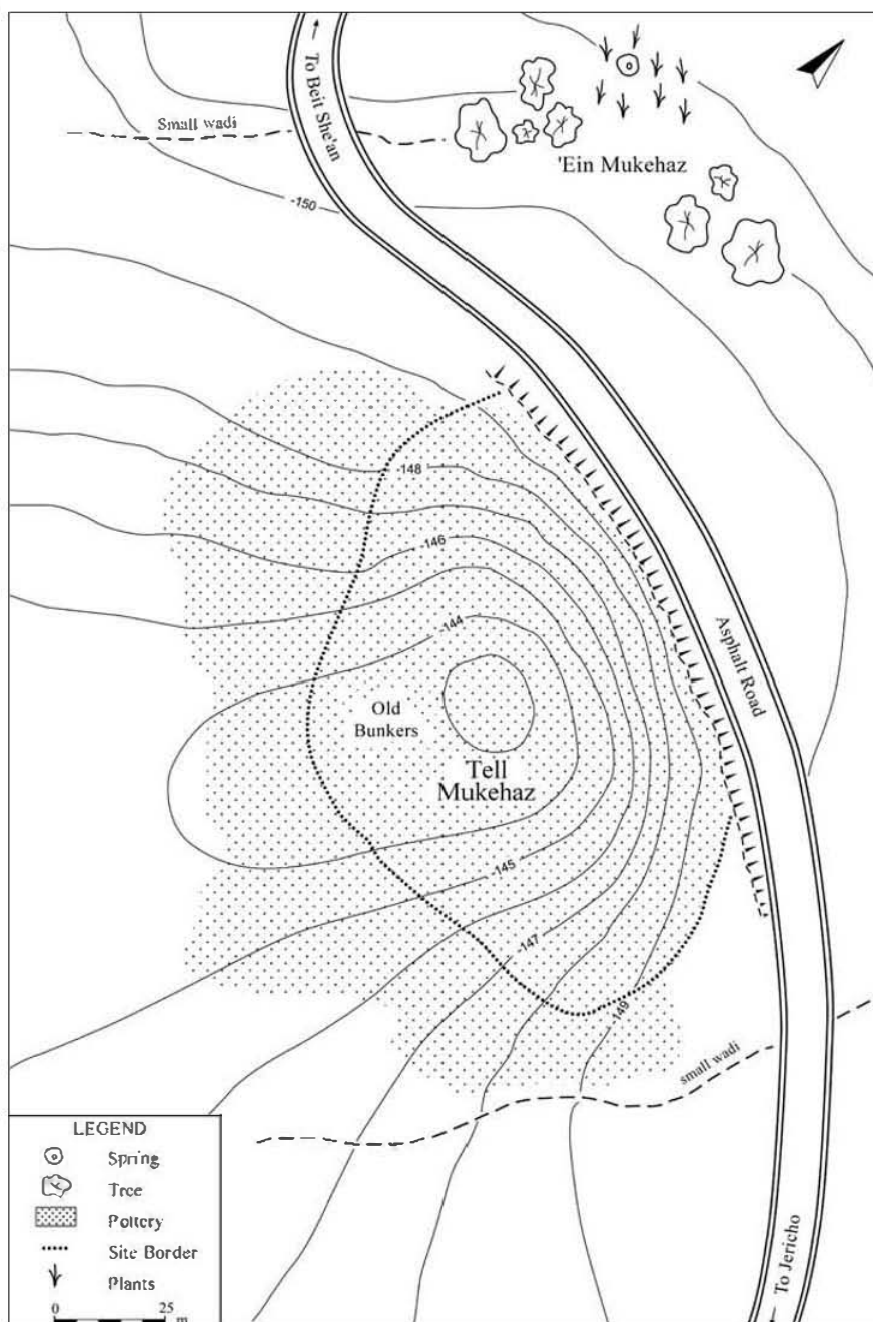
Nearest road: Beit She'an–Jericho
(B10), next to the site

Visit: Dec. 1988; 200 sherds

A small tell in the southern Beit She'an Valley, near 'Ein Mukehaz and a curve of the Beit She'an–Jericho road.

The tell is slightly elevated above the valley plain. At its top is a small sheikh's tomb and modern Arab graves. The Beit She'an–Jericho road curves westward, and cuts through about 100 m of the tell's northern part. To the west, east and south are cultivated fields. Military trenches dug at the top of the site exposed building stones, basalt fragments and many sherds. The steeper slope faces north.

Robinson visited in May 1852, describing it as: "...and reached 'Ein Mak-huz at 1.55..." 'Ein Mak-huz is not as large as several of the other fountains; but the water is good. It was the *seventh* fountain or stream, to which we had come to-day; and all but two of them in the Ghor itself. This abundance of water was quite unexpected to us; and accounts perhaps sufficiently for the greater fertility of this region... Without any great apparent descent, we had passed from



52. Plan of Tell Mukehaz (1) and the nearby spring of 'Ein Mukehaz, 2003.

the fields of wheat yet green at Teyasir in the morning, to the harvest home and threshing floors of the Ghor at midday. The people of Tubas encamped around 'Ein Makhuz were now in mid-harvest. They were dwelling in tents and booths, with their women and children, horses and donkeys, dogs and poultry; the latter probably, that they might thrive on the scattered grain. We pitched our tent by their side, and enjoyed the lively scene. The people were kind and hospitable." (Robinson and Smith 1856: 314).

Tzori (1962: site 95), writes: "Four km south-east of Tirat Zvi is a small tell (50×40 m). The 'Ein Mukhaz springs are to the north-west, and south of it is the road to Jericho. On top of the tell are modern Arab tombs. A small amount of pottery was found on its slopes..."

The site seems to have been a road station or a small fort, connected to the road and the spring.

Pottery (summary of the different surveys): Chalcolithic; Early Bronze I-II; Middle Bronze II; Late Bronze; Iron I-II; Persian; Hellenistic; Early and Late



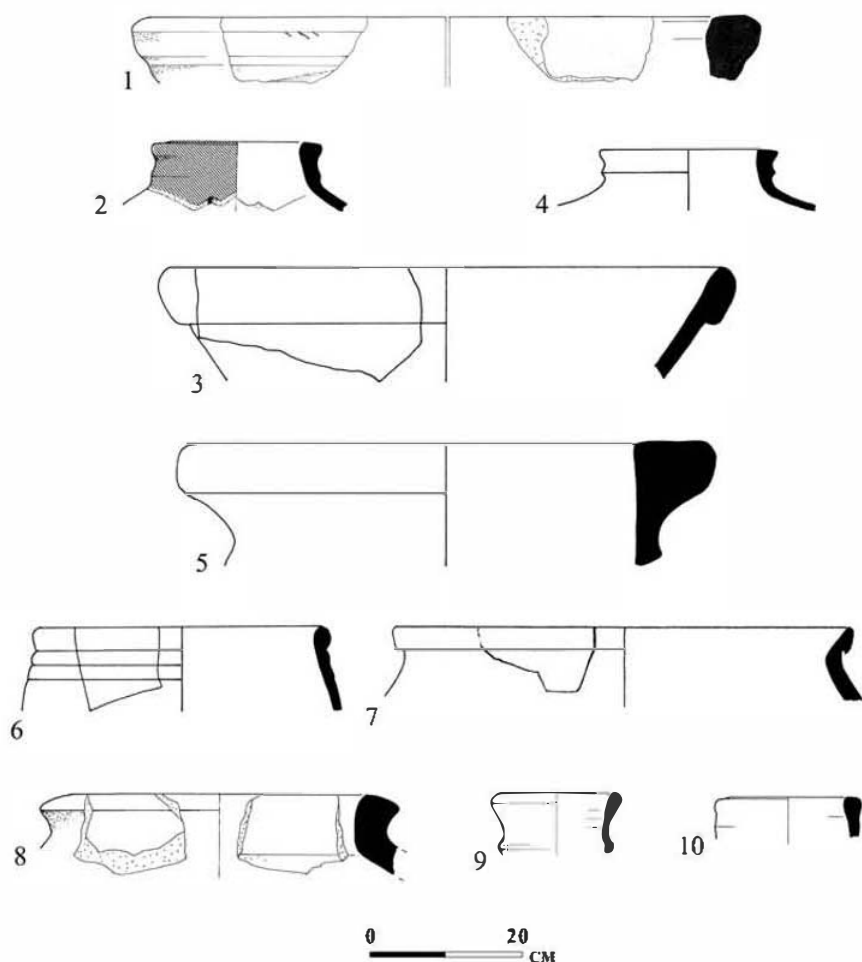
53. Tell Mukehaz (1), view to the south-east, 1989. At left is seen Christ's thorn Jujube (*Ziziphus spina-christi*) trees marking 'Ein Mukehaz (A. Zertal).

Roman; Byzantine; Early Moslem; Middle Ages; Ottoman.

Additional surveys: Tzori 1962: site 95; Kohn-Tavor 2010: site 96; 2012a: site 96.

Identification: identification with Yokme'am, a site setting the southern border of Solomon's Fifth District (I Kgs 4: 12), see Chapter 2.

Additional Bibliography: It seems that this is Guérin's "small tell, of no name" (1969: 281); Bar 2014a: site 5.



54. Pottery from Tell Mukehaz (1): 1. Krater, buff, Chal; 2. Jar, lt brn, rd slip, IA I?; 3. Krater, buff, Pers; 4. Jar, brn, well fird, Ir II; 5. Basin, gr, Pers; 6. Bowl, brn, well fird, MB II; 7. CP A, dk brn, Ir I; 8. Jar, buff, EB; 9. Juglet, pk, LB; 10. Jug, brn, Ir II.

Site 12: 20-20/11/1

TELL TZAF

Israel grid: 2019/2014	Soil quality: 6
UTM grid: 7398/5886	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 280 m b.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: none
Name type: ancient, but not on map	Nearest water source: Jima'in spring
Site type: tell	(162c), 300 m distant
Area: 50 dunams (5 ha)	Nearest road: Shechem–Abu Sus (B8),
Topography: on hillocks	3 km distant
Rock type: Dead Sea Group	Visit: Feb. 2001; 50 sherds
Soil type: alluvium	

Low tell on three hillocks in the low-lying part (the *Zor* flood plain) of the Jordan Valley, about 2 km south-east of Tirat Zvi.

The tell is first mentioned in Tzori's survey (1962: site 64): "This tell, situated 300 m south of Tell Jima'in, spreads over two or three fairly low hillocks. On the tell surface are strewn sherds and flint items, all Chalcolithic...the western hill-ock, measuring 200×200 m, is rounded and fairly flat. Over its surface sherds and flint items are scattered in abundance..."

Near the site Tzori (1962: sites 159, 160), followed by Kohn-Tavor (2010: sites 108, 109), mentions two additional find spots: 400 m south-west of the tell is es-Sufun (Israel grid: 2017/2010) – sherd and flint scatters on two natural hillocks with prehistoric flint tools, Chal or EB I pottery and Rom-Byz sherds; and to the west is 'Ein es-Safuh/Khor es-Sufun (Israel grid: 2016/2016) – with remains of constructions and Rom-Byz pottery.

Salvage excavations were conducted at the site by Gophna in 1977–78 and 1980 (Gophna 1993, with additional bibliography). 100 sq. m were dug with the following results: From the Pottery Neolithic – shallow pits with ash, pebbles and cubic clay bricks. From the Chalcolithic Period – structures, flint artifacts, pottery, an animal figurine, a seal impression and other items. At least two building phases were identified. ¹⁴C testing yielded the calibrated date 6980 ± 180 BP, or close to 5000 BCE.

From 2004 to 2007 the excavations were renewed under the direction of Y. Garfinkel of the Hebrew University (Garfinkel and Rowan 2005; Dag and Garfinkel 2007; Garfinkel, Ben-Shlomo and Freikeman 2007; Garfinkel, Freikeman, Ben-Shlomo and Vered 2007; Ben-Shlomo et al. 2009; Garfinkel et al. 2009). A detailed survey of the 5-ha site revealed that it spread over three hillocks (eastern, western and southern). The main period of occupation was the Middle Chalcolithic Period (sometimes referred to as Late Pottery Neolithic

– post-Wadi Rabah phase). Recent radiometric dates (Streit and Garfinkel 2015) from the domestic quarter and a well excavated at the site suggest that it was occupied in the last quarter of the 6th millennium BCE, and abandoned in the first quarter of the 5th millennium. The absolute dating of Tell Tsaf has further implications for the synchronization of the protohistory of the Levant. The ceramic assemblage of Tell Tsaf included delicately painted ceramic sherds (so-called ‘Tell Tzaf ware’). Comparable motifs have been identified in ceramic assemblages of contemporary Ubaid sites in northern Mesopotamia. This is a fine example of a little researched connection between the Ubaid culture and the Middle Chalcolithic of the southern Levant. The findings of Tell Tsaf expand the southwestern border of the Ubaid sphere of influence, and shed new light on long-distance interaction in protohistory.

In Area B, situated on the southern hillock, a well, 5.15 m deep and 1.2 m in diameter, was exposed. In the bottom restorable Chalcolithic jars were found. Near the well mouth were traces of a bead and flint production area.

In Area C, the main area of excavation, situated on the western hillock, the main architectural remains were excavated. In Stratum I were meagre remains from the Byzantine and Early Moslem period, above a sterile earth layer (Stratum II). Strata III, IV and lower IV were all dated to the Middle Chalcolithic period, and show continuation and development of the same architectural traditions. Several large courtyard houses were exposed, containing typical Chalcolithic broad rooms and rounded installations (probably silos). The masonry is of sun-dried mud bricks with wall widths ranging from 80 to 140 cm. Some of the walls survived to a height of 80 cm.

During the excavation four architectural complexes with dividing walls between them were noted. In Complex I a 5×10 m broad room was exposed with circular rooms and silos around it. An adult burial was found inside one of the silos. Evidence of food preparation and consumption was found in the large courtyard. In the other complexes similar constructions and findings were noted, including infant jar burials.

The finds include Middle Chalcolithic pottery, and especially the noteworthy ‘Tell Tzaf ware’, flint (including traded obsidian – ‘volcanic glass’), stone and bone tools, beads (of bone, stone or shell), zoomorphic and anthropomorphic figurines, seal clay impressions, etc.

In 2013 the excavations were renewed under the direction of D. Rosenberg of the University of Haifa in collaboration with the Eurasia Department of the German Archaeological Institute in Berlin. Excavation in the western hillock (Area C) continued (Rosenberg et al. 2014), and a new Area E was opened in the western part of the hillock in order to assess the actual size of the dwelling complexes of the site. This newly initiated long-term project is in its early stages, and further excavations and research are expected to shed more light

on the site and the Middle Chalcolithic period in the Jordan Valley.

Pottery (summary of the different surveys and excavations at the site and its surroundings): Chalcolithic (main period); Persian; Early and Late Roman; Byzantine; Early Moslem.

Additional surveys: Tzori 1962: site 64; Kohn-Tavor 2010: site 110; 2012b: site 110.



Site 13: 20-20/21/1

TELL JIMA'IN

Israel grid: 2024/2016

UTM grid: 7403/5886

Elevation: 280 m b.s.l., 10 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient, but not on map

Site type: tell

Area: 3 dunams (3000 sq. m)

Topography: hill

Rock type: Dead Sea Group

Soil type: alluvium

Soil quality: 7

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Nearest water source: Jima'in spring
(162c), at the site

Nearest road: Shechem–Abu Sus (B8),
3 km distant

Visit: Feb. 2001

A tell in the bottom terrace (*Zor*) of the Jordan Valley, about 300 m east of Tell Tzaf and 2.5 km south-east of kibbutz Tirat-Zvi.

The tell is first mentioned in Tzori's survey (1962: site 63): "This small site (about 70×50 m)...is not recorded in any map. It rises above the Jordan and its steepness is well seen from the west and more so from the east, where the slope is very steep (part of it has collapsed into the Jordan). At the foot of the tell, on the north-east, is the small Jima'in spring... At the foot of the tell, in the north-west, are scattered ancient building stones. 100 m westward, there are several hillocks, over which are strewn Chalcolithic period sherds and flint items."

According to the Kefar Rupin Map Survey (Kohn-Tavor 2010: site 111; 2012b: site 111), the site is part of the Chalcolithic site of Tell Tzaf (Site 12). Its name, which means 'group' in Arabic, suggests the group of springs west of the tell.

The site does not appear on the PEF map.

Pottery (summary of the different surveys): Neolithic; Chalcolithic; Early Bronze I-II; Middle Bronze II; Late Bronze; Iron I-II; Persian; Early Roman; Byzantine; Early Moslem.

Additional surveys: Tzori 1962: site 63; Kohn-Tavor 2010: site 111; 2012b: site 111.

Site 14: 19-20/20/1

KHALET ABU GHALIYAN

Israel grid: 1923/2001	Soil quality: 4
UTM grid: 7302/5870	Cultivation: field crops
Elevation: 15 m a.s.l., 50 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: none
Name type: nearest place	Nearest water source: Qa'un springs
Site type: sherd scatter	(132), 2 km distant
Area: 1.2 dunams (1200 sq. m)	Nearest road: Shechem–Beit She'an
Topography: spur	(B7), 1 km distant
Rock type: Avdat Group	Visit: March 1986; 62 sherds
Soil type: alluvium and <i>terra-rossa</i>	

Sherd scatter over a wide and rocky spur descending eastward from the 'Iraq el-Ḥamam ridge to the Beit She'an Valley, about 2.3 km west north-west of Bardaleh.

The sherds are scattered among rocky areas in a cultivated field. It seems that dismantled structures once stood here, or it was a nomad tented camp.

Pottery: Intermediate Bronze – 80%; unidentified – 20%.

Additional surveys: none.



Site 15: 19-20/50/1

EL-QUWA'IN

Israel grid: 1952/2006	Soil quality: 5
UTM grid: 7329/5875	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 59 m b.s.l., 20 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: none
Name type: nearest place	Nearest water source: 'Ein el-'Iraq
Site type: structure	(168b), 1.2 km distant
Area: 0.5 dunam (500 sq. m)	Nearest road: Shechem–Beit She'an
Topography: spur	(B7), 1.2 km distant
Rock type: Dead Sea Group	Visit: Dec. 1989; 14 sherds
Soil type: alluvium	

This is a solitary structure on the edge of a spur which slopes northward to a shallow valley, about 2 km south-south-west of Tell Mukehaz.



55. The Byzantine structure foundations at el-Quwa'in, view to the north-west, 1989.

The structure measures 8×6 m, and its walls are built of large fieldstones. The wall orientation is from south-east to north-west. From the northern wall a short wall extends eastward, connecting to another small structure, measuring 4×2 m.

This is a farm or a structure, part of a ruined complex from the Byzantine period.

Pottery: Byzantine – 100%.

Additional surveys: none.



Site 16: 19-20/61/3

TELL MUKEHAZ (2)

Israel grid: 1963/2012

UTM grid: 7342/5881

Elevation: 130 m b.s.l., 15 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: small

Area: 1 dunam (1000 sq. m)

Topography: spur

Rock type: Lisan formation

Soil type: alluvium

Soil quality: 8

Cultivation: field crops

Cisterns: none

Nearest water source: 'Ein Mukehaz
(159), 400 m distant

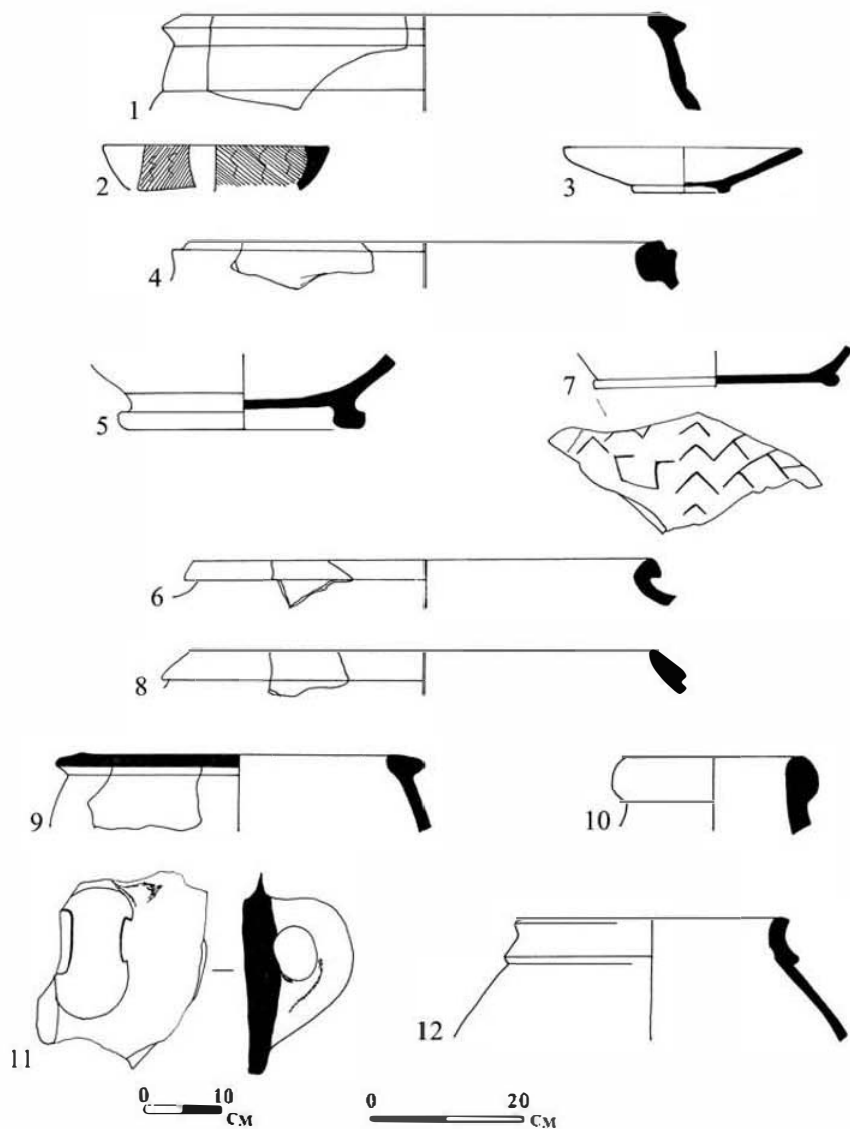
Nearest road: Beit She'an–Jericho
(B10), next to the site

Visit: Jan. 1989; 64 sherds

This is a small site on a spur, about 200 m west of Tell Mukehaz (1).

Scattered building stones, and among them large concentrations of sherds were found over a cultivated hill.

A small multi-period site (several houses) stood here. It seems that



56. Pottery from Tell Mukehaz (2): 1. Krater, dk brn, MB II; 2. Bowl, green glazed, MA; 3. Bowl, pk, MB II; 4. CP, dk brn, Ir II; 5. Base, 'mortaria', lt gr, Pers; 6, 8. CPs, dk brn, mica, Ir I; 7. Base of bowl, gr, plastic dec over bottom, MA; 9. Bowl, rd slip over the rim, Ir II; 10. Jar, buff, MA; 11. Handle, gr, Pers?; 12. Jar, buff, Hel.

unfortified sites existed during various periods around the spring of 'Ein Mukehaz, perhaps protected by the fortified site at Tell Mukehaz (1).

Pottery: Middle Bronze II – 5%; Iron I – 15%; Iron II – 35%; Persian – 2%; Hellenistic – 3%; Middle Ages – 4•%.

Additional surveys: none.



57. Tell Mukehaz (2), view to the south-west, 1990. In the background is 'Iraq el-Ḥamam ridge.



Site 17: 19-2•/9•/2

SHALEM – ROMAN CAMP

Israel grid: 1995/2••7

UTM grid: 7374/5877

Elevation: 192 m b.s.l., • m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: military camp

Area: 5• dunams (5 ha)

Topography: plain

Rock type: Dead Sea Group

Soil type: silt and marsh

Soil quality: 7

Cultivation: field crops

Cisterns: none

Nearest water source: 'Ein Ibrahim
(162a), 4•• m distant

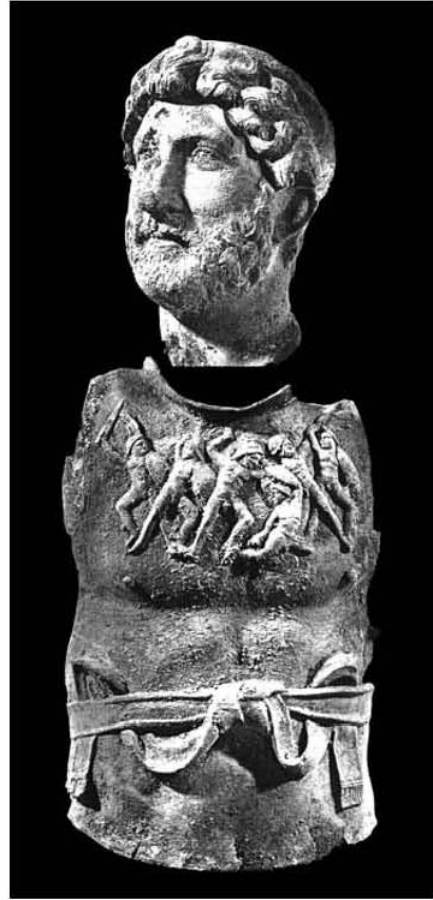
Nearest road: Beit She'an–Jericho
(B1•), 2.5 km distant

Visit: Dec.1989; 5• sherds

A Roman military camp, partially excavated, but not yet fully published, in the Nahal Bezeq flood plain, about 3•• m west of Tel Shalem.

In 197●, R. Leitner from Kibbutz Shluhot announced the discovery of an inscription of the Sixth Roman Legion (Ferrata), close to Tell Shalem. The inscription, set in *tabula ansata*, belongs to the memorial inscriptions to the Legions (HA 34-35: 7).

In 1975 a bronze statue of Emperor Hadrian wearing armour was discovered at the site. This statue was described by Foerster (1975: 4●) as follows: "the monumental statue, which seemingly was over 2 m high, made of cast bronze and composed from several parts assembled with lumps of lead. It seems that the statue depicts Hadrian at the commencement of his reign, being 45 years old. His expression is serious and realistic...Two more similar statues have been found in Rome and in Thasos, Greece...Apart from several fragments this is perhaps the only monumental bronze statue of a ruler wearing armour...according to the parts discovered it is likely that the Emperor wore a tunic. The armour over it is of Hellenistic type, and on the front are plastically rendered anatomical details such as the nipples and the chest and abdominal muscles. The armour is decorated with a relief...of a battle scene of classical Greek design...also illustrated on it is a remarkably designed belt... the military cloak (*pludamentum*) rests on the Emperor's shoulders and his left hand, a clear symbol of Emperors while serving as military commanders. To the lower part are attached lines of scales...it seems that the statue was executed in the style of Polykleitos (a Greek sculptor living at the end of the 5th century BCE)... The statue was possibly placed in the legion's camp on the occasion of the Emperor's visit to the East in 129-13● CE, and served there in the worship of the Emperor."



58. Shalem – Roman Camp: Hadrian's bronze statue, found in the site (courtesy G. Foerster).

As a result of the discovery, two excavation seasons were conducted aimed at locating and unearthing the Roman camp. In a preliminary description of

the excavation (Eisenberg 1988: 20), it was noted that: "The purpose of the excavation, managed by Gideon Foerster (Department of Antiquities) and Mordecai Gichon (Tel Aviv University), was to try to determine the area of the Roman camp, the boundaries of which were only approximately identified. It was a permanent camp, each side of it being 250-300 m. In the western part were structures built of bricks over stone foundations. The pottery is characteristic of the 2nd century CE. In the southern part remains of a bathhouse were exposed, with canals, pipes and typical plastered pools. One of the rooms (12×8 m) was surrounded by stone benches and had a floor decorated with geometric shapes, with no contemporary parallels." (*HA* 65-66: 9).

During our visit to the camp only a few remains of the excavation were found, and the site has been covered by silt.

Pottery: Late Roman (2nd century CE) – 100%.

Additional surveys: Gergel 1991; Kohn-Tavor 2010: site 104; 2012a: site 104.

Additional Bibliography: *HA* 57-58: 17.



Site 18: 19-20/90/1

TELL EL-RIDHGHAIH (TEL SHALEM)

also in the PEF map. Tell er-Radrah in Guérin's map

Israel grid: 1998/2007

UTM grid: 7377/5876

Elevation: 199 m b.s.l., 20 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient and on map

Site type: tell

Area: 15 dunams (1.5 ha)

Topography: flood plain

Rock type: Lisan formation

Soil type: silt and marsh

Soil quality: 8

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Nearest water source: 'Ein Ibrahim
(162a), at the site

Nearest road: Beit She'an–Jericho
(B10), 3 km distant

Visit: Dec. 1989; 40 sherds

Medium-sized tell in the flood plain marshes of Nahal Bezeq, 1 km south of the stream riverbed (now a canal) and about 2 km south of Kibbutz Tirat Zvi.

The kidney-shaped tell consists of two hills with a saddle between them. In the eastern high part is the upper city (the acropolis), with an area of 2–3 dunams (2000–3000 sq. m). A military strongpoint with trenches was dug in 1948 or later. West of this area is the lower part of the site – the lower city.

The tell is encircled by roads, with fishponds to the east of it. To the north

and at its foot is 'Ein Ibrahim, with a pumping station and a small pool. Close to the spring is the ruined tomb of Sheik Ridhghah or 'Wali Sheik Salim'.

Robinson visited the place on May 15th 1852, describing it as follows: "...and at 4.5● we came to Tell Ridhghah in the plain, with a few foundations upon it. At its foot, on the north, is a pleasant fountain, and a Wely called Sheikh Salim, with a few huts around. As we advanced, the rays of the morning sun began to gild the tops of the mountains of Gilboa behind us." (Robinson and Smith 1856: 315).

Guérin (1969: 281) visited it on April 187●, and was impressed by the fertility of the plateau.

The British Survey describes it: "Tell er Ridhghah (Q m). A low mound, apparently artificial. On the north a good spring and a few ruined houses, with the little ruined dome of Sheikh Salim." (Conder and Kitchener 1882: 247).

Abel (1913: 221-222), who visited the site in February 191●, mentions ruins, burial caves, and the battle between Beit Shean and Pella ("Al-Ghadrah Day" – January 23rd, 635), which took place in its vicinity.

Albright (1924-1925: 43) visited in April 1925 writing: "The pottery strewn over the surface of this low mound... is almost entirely 'Arabic, though a few stray sherds of the Bronze Age suggested that a village had been located here in the early period. The absence of Roman or Byzantine pottery showed that Tell er-Ridghah cannot be identified with the Salumias of Eusebius, which the latter places eight miles from Scythopolis and combines with the Salim of John 3:23."



59. Tell el-Ridhghah, view to the south-east, 1989. At left, by the palm, 'Ein Ibrahim (A. Zertal).

Tzori (1962: site 66) describes it: "The site is not large (its area is ca. 100×800 m)... in the north it stands up to 4 m high. North-west of the site is a spring from which a stream flows into a pool... During the War of Independence trenches and pits were dug, especially on the south-eastern slopes, exposing stones and pottery from the EB, MB II, LB or Early Ir I, Ir II, Per, and Hel periods."

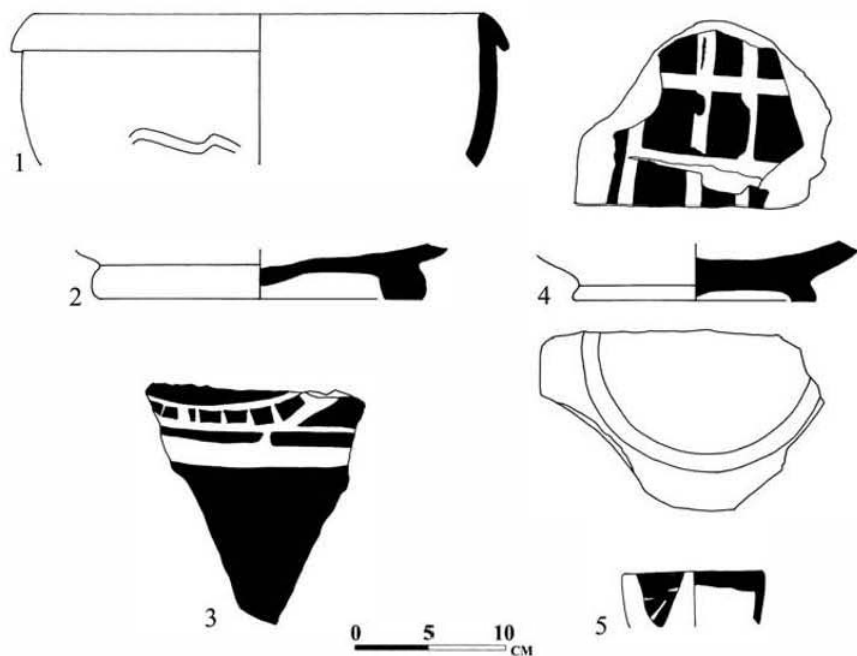
Tzori (1962: site 67), followed by Kohn-Tavor (2010: site 105), notes a place called Kh. 'Al'al (1999/2008) north of the tell, with remains dating to the Epipalaeolithic, Neolithic/Chal, EB I, LB?, Ir I-II, and Byz.

Eisenberg conducted a salvage excavation in the plain north-west of the tell (1987). A 4.5–5 m thick brick wall was found. The finds are very homogeneous and dated to EB I. Another wall, 1.7 m thick, was found 10 m north of the site's wall, and a fill between these walls was noted. This might be the remains of a glacis. The excavator interprets the finds as a double fortification system encircling a settlement of about 5 ha area. He adds that previous surveys show that the area of the entire EB I settlement was larger than the fortified area, and included unfortified sections (Eisenberg 1987: 31).

According to the Kefar Rupin Map Survey (Kohn-Tavor 2010: sites 102 and 103; 2012a: sites 102, 103) additional dated find spots are found in the vicinity of the tell, and include a Mamluk sherd scatter between the tell and the Roman



60. Tell el-Ridhghah, aerial view northwards, 2013. In the centre can be seen the acropolis with a modern military strongpoint on it. Above it (north of the tell) can be seen a modern fishpond and the source of 'Ein Ibrahim. Above them, the location of the Early Bronze Age fortified site (A. Solomon).



61. Pottery from Tell el-Ridhghah: 1. Krater, gr, EM; 2. Base, buff, EM; 3-5. Sherds of bowls and jars, yel and green glazed, MA.

camp (1996/2006), possibly connected to the local sugar cane industry, and possible remains of a pottery workshop dated to the Rom, Byz and EM periods (1995/2006).

Pottery (Summary of the surveys in the tell and its surroundings): Chalcolithic; Early Bronze I; Middle Bronze II; Iron I-II; Persian; Hellenistic; Early and Late Roman; Byzantine; Early Moslem; Middle Ages.

Additional surveys: Tzori 1962: sites 66-67; Kohn-Tavor 2010: site 102; 2012a: site 102.

Additional Bibliography: Le Strange 1890: 439 (about the battle of el-Ridhghah); Eisenberg 1988; 1996; Bar 2014a: site 7.

Site 19: 20-20/00/1

TELL MOLIKAT

Israel grid: 2004/2003

UTM grid: 7384/5873

Elevation: 230 m b.s.l., 5 m a.s.a.

Name type: ancient and on map

Site type: small tell

Area: 3 dunams (3000 sq. m)

Topography: valley

Rock type: Dead Sea Group

Soil type: silt and marsh

Soil quality: 7

Cultivation: field crops

Cisterns: none

Nearest water source: 'Ein Ibrahim
(162a), 700 m distantNearest road: Shechem–Abu Sus (B8),
2.5 km distant

Visit: Dec. 1989; 27 sherds

A small tell in the marshy floodplain south of Nahal Bezeq, about 700 m south-east of Tell el-Ridhghah. The tell rises several metres above the plain, and its surroundings are cultivated with field crops. It seems that a considerable part of the tell is beneath the silt. There is little sherd scatter.

Tzori (1962: site 65) visited it, describing it as: "A small hillock, of area 40×20 m rising 3 m above its vicinity. Shards from the Middle Bronze II, Persian, Byzantine and Early Moslem periods were collected. Flint artifacts were gathered, and east of the site over a large area more flint items and shards were collected."

In the Kefar Rupin Map Survey (Kohn-Tavor 2010: site 107; 2012b: site 107) sherds were also collected from the Chal, IB (?), Ir I-II, Pers, Hel, ER, LR, Byz, and EM periods. In addition, flint finds from the Middle Palaeolithic and Chal periods were collected.

Pottery (summary of the different surveys in the tell and its surroundings): Chalcolithic; Iron I-II; Persian; Hellenistic; Early and Late Roman; Byzantine; Early Moslem.

Flint: Middle Palaeolithic and Chalcolithic.

Additional surveys: Tzori 1962: site 65; Kohn-Tavor 2010: site 107; 2012b: site 107.

Site 20: 19-19/39/1

KHALLET EL-MALIḤ

Israel grid: 1932/1998

UTM grid: 7311/5867

Elevation: 35 m a.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: medium size

Area: 3.5 dunams (3500 sq. m)

Topography: low spur

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: colluvial-alluvial

Soil quality: 8

Cultivation: field crops

Cisterns: none

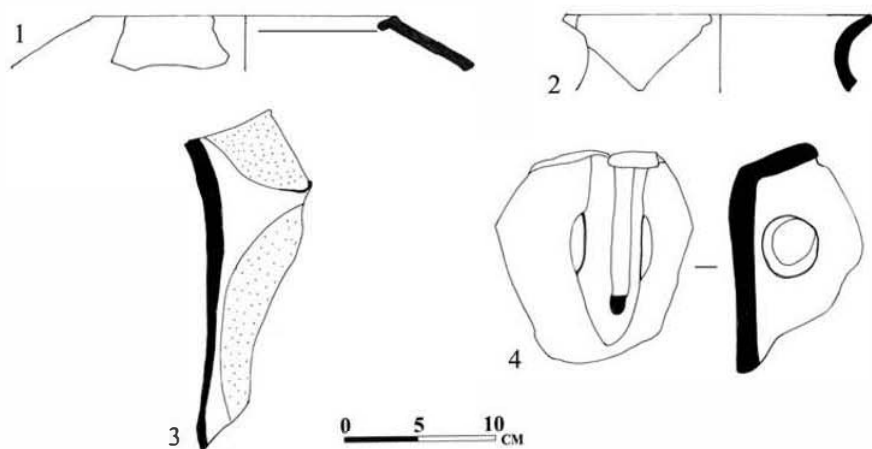
Nearest water source: Qa'un springs
(132), 1.5 km distantNearest road: Shechem–Beit She'an
(B7), next to the siteVisits: March 1986, Nov. 1989; 102
sherds

This site is on a broad spur in the floodplain between Wadis Shubash, Qa'un and Ha'shneh, 2 km west-north-west of Bardaleh.

The site covers the edge of a low rocky step descending to a ploughed field. There are two prominent structures, each about 15×8 m, covered by cleared stone heaps. At the foot of the rocky step and abutting it are additional remains of structures and walls. Structures were also traced in the eastern part of the cultivated field, about 100 m east of the site's centre.



62. The site at Khallet el-MaliḤ, view to the north-west, 1989. In the background – 'Iraql-Hamam ridge (A. Zertal).



63. Pottery from Khallet el-Malih, all IB, well fired: 1. HM, dk gr; 2. Jar, buff; 3. Enveloped ledge handle, buff; 4. Lug handle, lt gr.

In the northern part of the central area is a circular structure, about 10 m in diameter, well-built with medium-sized stones. Many IB sherds were found scattered over the entire site.

Pottery: Intermediate Bronze – 100%.

Stone: Two rock-cut conical mortars and two rounded mortars: one of limestone and the other of basalt (see Eitam 2005: 680–681).

Additional surveys: none.



Site 21: 19-19/38/1

WADI SALMAN (2)

Israel grid: 1938/1985

UTM grid: 7317/5854

Elevation: 70 m a.s.l., 50 m b.s.a.

Name type: nearest place

Site type: enclosure and courtyard

Area: 7 dunams (7000 sq. m)

Topography: valley fringes

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 5

Cultivation: none

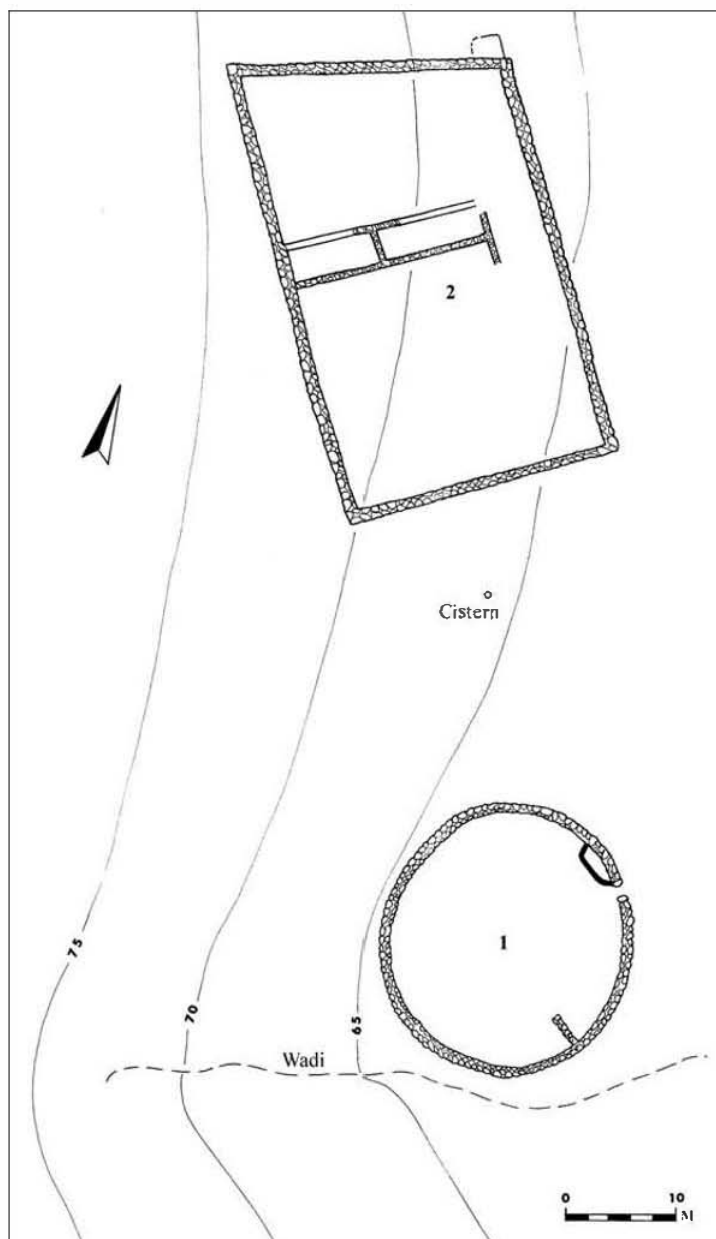
Cisterns: 1

Nearest water source: 'Ein Bardleh
(168), 1.5 km distant

Nearest road: Shechem–Beit She'an
(B7), 1.2 km distant

Visits: April 1986, Nov. 1993; 50 sherds

An enclosure site in a hilly area on a spur in the northern fringes of Wadi Salman, about 1.5 km south-west of the village of Bardaleh. Above it, and about 400 m to the south-west, rises Wadi Salman's Roman fortress (Zertal 2008: site



64. Plan of Wadi Salman (2). The round enclosure is of the IA, and the trapezoidal one is of the Byz Period, 1989.

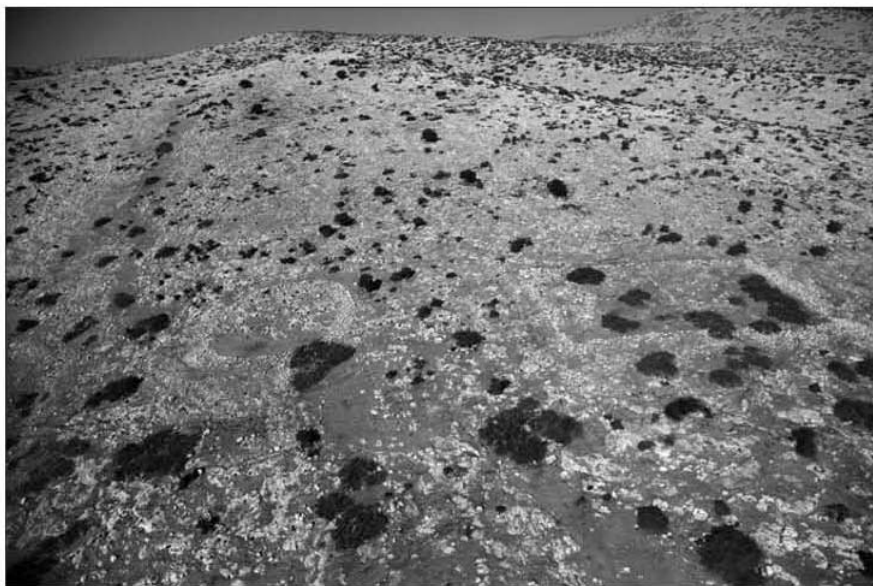
63). The spur slopes downwards to the east, and there is a good view from it to the Bardaleh hills.

The place has two separate stone-built enclosures. Their construction is different, suggesting that they were built at different times.

1. At the south-east of the site is a circular enclosure about 22 m in diameter. The thickness of the encircling wall is 1.1 m, built of two rows of large stones. In the low north-eastern part of the enclosure is an opening 1 m wide. Inside of it is a compartment or dwelling. Another short wall protrudes into the enclosure from its eastern side. Most of the sherds are from the IA I-II periods.
2. In the north of the site, about 30 m north-north-west of the circular enclosure, is an irregular trapezoidal courtyard. Its sides measure 45 m (west), 40 m (east), and 27 m (both north and south). Construction is good, with large stones. Inside this building is an elongated (22×4 m) inner structure divided into rooms. Most of the sherds in this enclosure and around it are Byz.

Between the two structures is a rock-cut cistern.

It is likely that the site at this location, probably a small farm, was established during the IA I when the circular enclosure was built, and continued into the IA II. During the Byz period, some of the stones of the ancient site were apparently used to construct the trapezoidal courtyard. An interesting concentration



65. Aerial view of Wadi Salman (2), view to the west, 2013 (A. Solomon).